Harper's

# BAZAAR

THE PERFORMANCE ISSUE

## NATALIE PORTMAN *Breaks Character*

LOUIS VUITTON

LOUIS VUITTON

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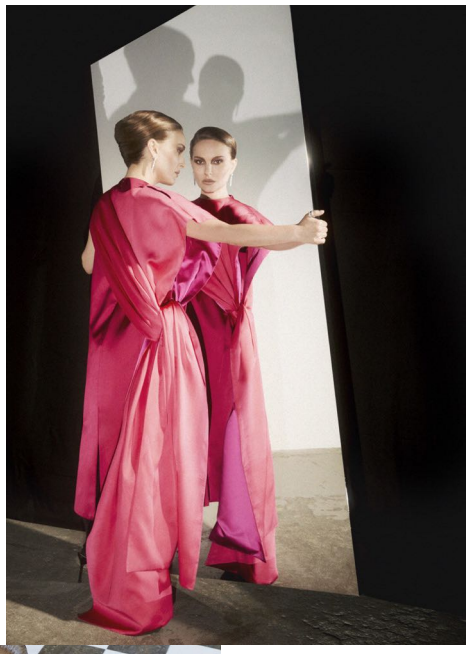
# EDITOR'S LETTER

## *On* PERFORMANCE



Above, on Natalie Portman: Celine cape and dress. Tiffany & Co. Bird on a Rock by Tiffany Wings earrings. Left: Alaïa dress. Dolce & Gabbana mules. Below: A QR code to take you straight to harpersbazaar.com.

Samira Nasr

I'm writing this from Paris as the Spring 2026 shows are wrapping up. One glorious night, I had the chance to see Céline Dion during her residency at the Plénitude Arena. What really struck me about her performance was her unique ability to unite an entire stadium. It was just her up there—no background dancers—using her voice to bring us along on her journey. It was deeply moving. I was reminded of how vital performance can be. I'm sure there were people in the arena whose lives and experiences and politics differ from my own, but we could all come together to revel in the sheer joy of an incredible show.

That is the spirit in which we celebrate this issue's theme, performance. A performer can entertain us, transport us, and, crucially, connect us.

Our cover star, Natalie Portman, photographed by Carlijn Jacobs and styled by our style director at large, Malina Joseph Gilchrist, has consistently transported us over the years with great performances. In the coming months, she will deliver two more, in Cathy Yan's biting art-world satire, *The Gallerist,* and in Lena Dunham's hyped new rom-com, *Good Sex.* Both reveal a lighter, more humorous, though by no means less committed side of Portman, and that's by design. "Right now," she tells our executive editor, Leah Chernikoff, she's focusing on "a lot of joy. I think it's both for myself and what I hope to offer an audience. There's a lot of really heavy stuff going on ... and so it does feel like the biggest service you can do right now as an artist is to deliver some joy."

I have—we all have—watched Portman grow up. What I admire most about her is her integrity: She is deliberate about the choices she makes, not just in her work but in how she chooses to live her life, including the privacy she keeps for herself and for her growing family. (When we photographed her, she was pregnant with her third child, whom she welcomed in August!)

Elsewhere in this issue, I am thrilled to feature a range of dancers, musicians, writers, and actors whose work I have long revered. The dream team of John Legend, Lynn Nottage, and Whitney White came together in conversation to discuss their new stage adaptation of the classic American novel and film *Imitation of Life,* which also marks Legend's first musical. "At the core, this is a story about the American dream, with all of its contradictions and complications," says Nottage.

Sarah Hoover brings us the story of one of ballet's great modern partnerships—American Ballet Theatre's Isabella Boylston and James Whiteside—as they prepare to dance their final performances together. Boylston, who welcomed her first child this summer, returned to the barre six weeks after giving birth in order to be ready to partner with Whiteside before he retires next summer. "If I had to go onstage with him tonight in *Swan Lake,* with zero rehearsal, I'd still feel good about it," Boylston tells Hoover.

When this issue is on newsstands, our podcast, *The Good Buy,* cohosted by Chernikoff and our executive digital director, Lynette Nylander, will be back for its fourth season, available wherever you get your podcasts and on YouTube, featuring another incredible lineup of folks whose style we're obsessed with, including Paloma Elsesser and Kim Kardashian. Each episode is a reminder that getting dressed is the ultimate performance.

FROM TOP, NATALIE PORTMAN: CARLIJN JACOBS; FASHION EDITOR: MALINA JOSEPH GILCHRIST; HAIR: OLIVIER SCHAWALDER; MAKEUP: LUCY BRIDGE. FROM "FINE FORM": CHARLOTTE STOUVENOT; FASHION EDITOR: BERENGER PELC; MODEL: KAROLINA SPAKOWSKI; HAIR: AKEMI KISHIDA; MAKEUP: ANTHONY PREEL. NASR: EZRA PETRONIO/ART PARTNER/TRUNK ARCHIVE

DOLCE & GABBANA

PHOTOGRAPHED BY STEVEN MEISEL

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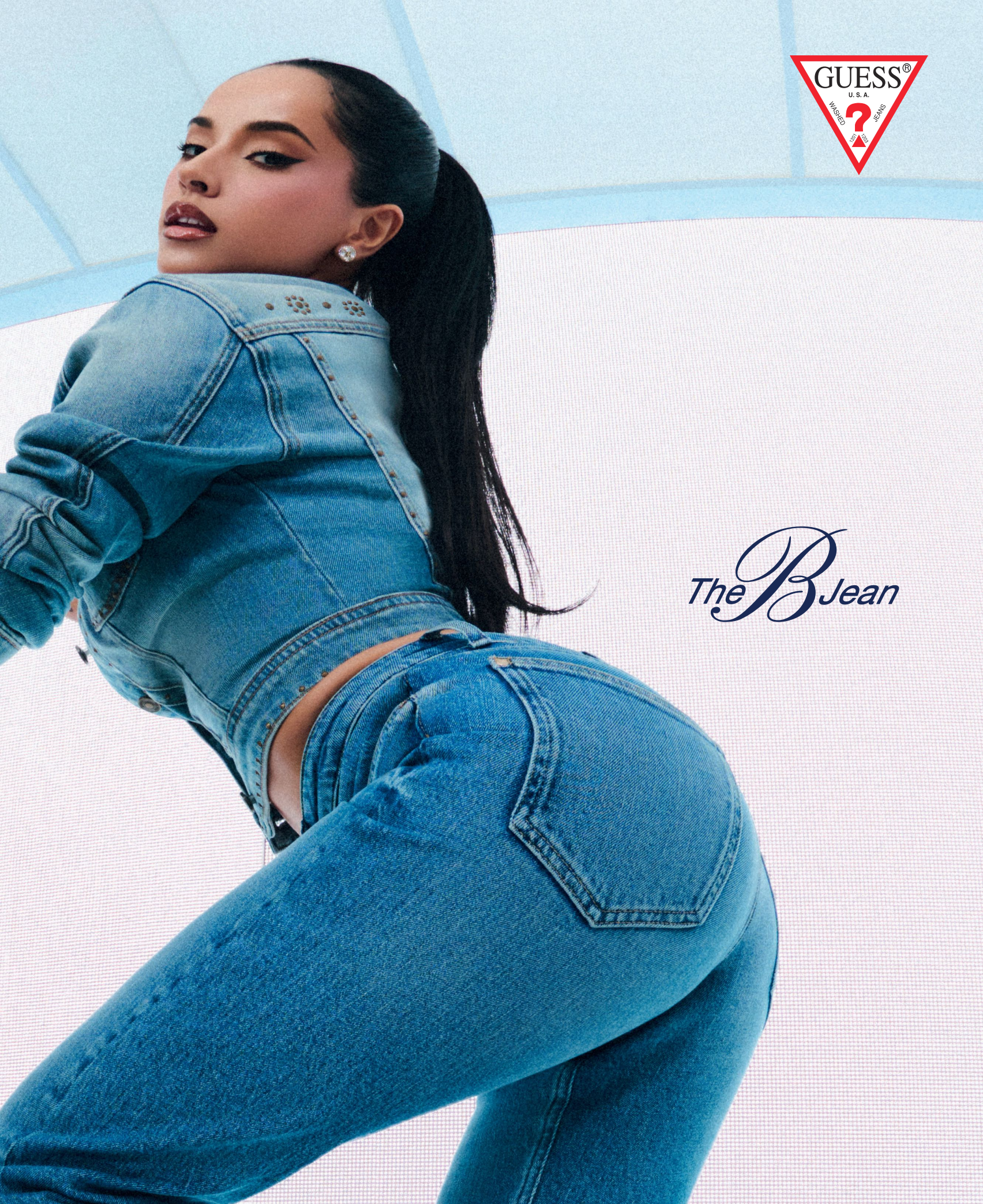
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# PLAYLIST

## *Introducing This Issue's* MUSIC DIRECTOR

# VINCE STAPLES

**FEATURED TRACKS**

1.


**"DROWN IN MY OWN TEARS"**
Ray Charles

2.

**"SABOTAGE"**
Beastie Boys

3.

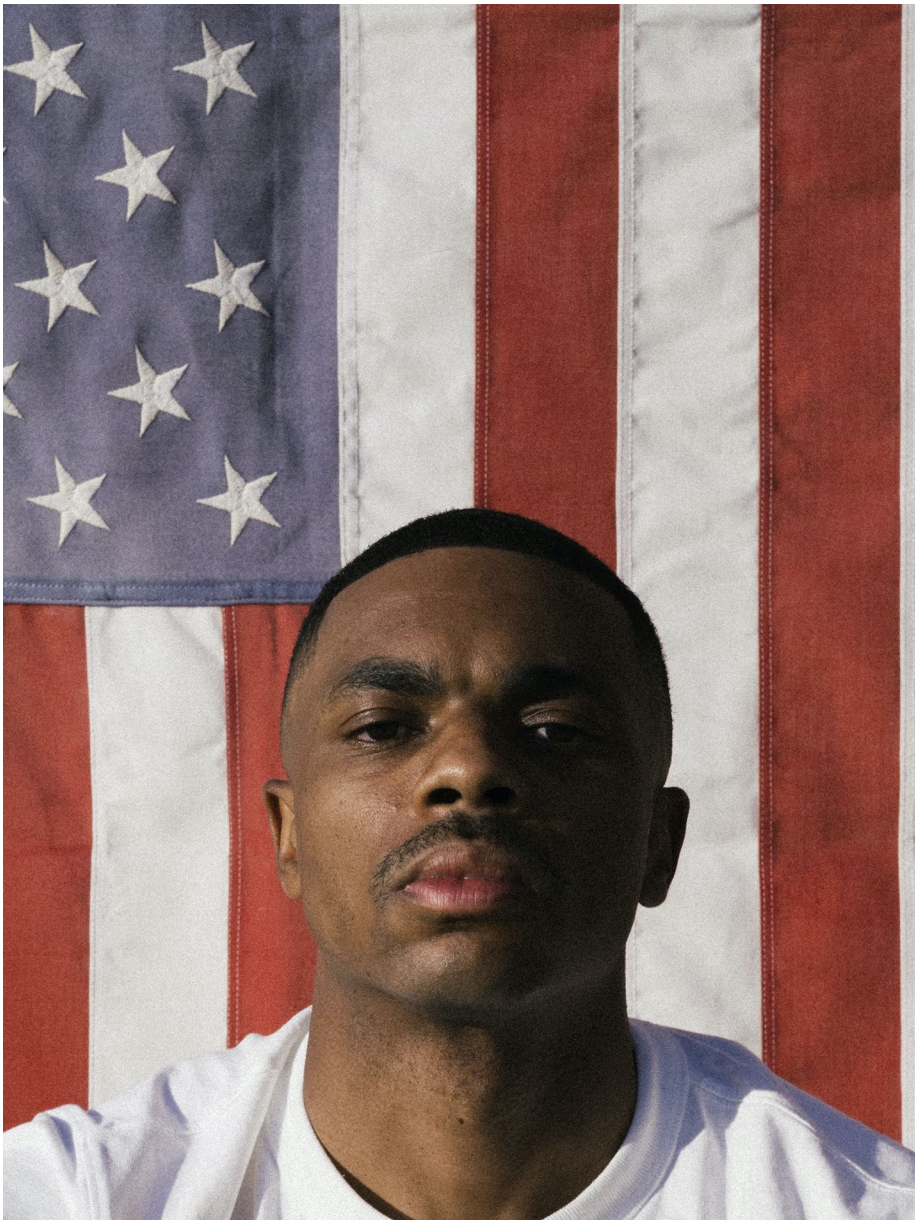
**"NICE SHOES"**
Steve Lacy

4.


**"VANITY"**
Blu

5.


**"I DON'T MIND"**
The Who



**6. "BEACHES IN TENNESSEE"**
Cage the Elephant

**7. "BLACKBERRY MARMALADE"**
Vince Staples

**8. "MAYBE"**
N.E.R.D

**9. "SHOW ME LOVE"**
Skilla Baby

**10. "EVERYBODY WANTS TO BE FAMOUS"**
Superorganism

**11. "SOUND IS VIBRATION"**
Atmosphere

**12. "GO! GO! GORILLA"**
Vince Staples

**13. "BEAUTIFUL THINGS 1ST SCENE/AUDITION"**
Reggie

**14. "LOW CLASS CONSPIRACY"**
Quasimoto

**15. "WHITE FLAG"**
Vince Staples

*Listen to Vince Staples's full playlist exclusively on Apple Music.*

*"Whatever you're* EXPERIENCING *at the current* MOMENT *is going to* TRANSLATE *in the* MUSIC *you* CREATE," *says Vince Staples. "You learn to* EMBRACE *that."*

That's precisely what the 33-year-old rapper did on his latest album, *Cry Baby,* an urgent, politically charged record that trades traditional beats for post-punk melodies and touches on subjects like policing, surveillance, and the myth of the American dream. Staples always strives for originality in his work, which is why he doesn't like to listen to music when he's writing his own songs. "I want to come up with the idea that feels most organic," he says. He took a similarly instinctive approach to assembling his playlist for this issue, compiling a list of songs that have been foundational for him as an artist and a performer. Ray Charles's soulful "Drown in My Own Tears" harks back to his childhood, while Blu's introspective "Vanity" reminds him of the kind of personal storytelling that first drew him to hip-hop and the Who's muscular 1965 cover of James Brown's "I Don't Mind" offers a lesson in transformation and reinterpretation. For Staples, it's the way a song can change you that makes it indelible. "It's a testament to what it meant to you in the moment you first heard it," he says. "Having that brought back to the forefront is a cool part of the process." MAXWELL RABB

RAY CHARLES, *RAY CHARLES:* COURTESY RHINO ENTERTAINMENT COMPANY; BEASTIE BOYS, *ILL COMMUNICATION:* CAPITOL RECORDS/UNIVERSAL MUSIC GROUP; STEVE LACY, "NICE SHOES" SINGLE: COURTESY RCA RECORDS; BLU, *HER FAVORITE COLO(U)R:* COURTESY NEW WORLD COLOR; THE WHO, *NEW GENERATION:* MCA RECORDS/UNIVERSAL MUSIC GROUP

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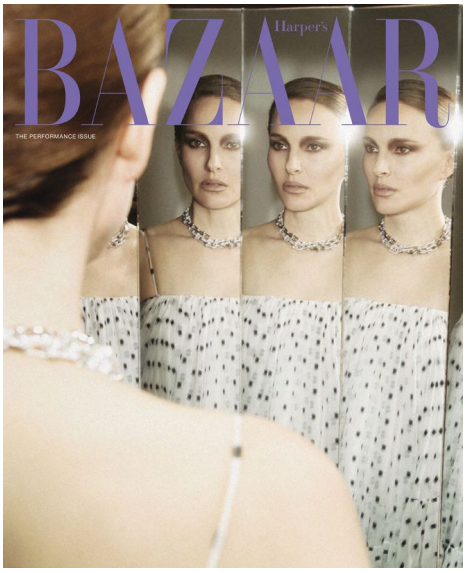
Far right, from "Last Dance," on Isabella Boylston: Altuzarra dress, $1,495; altuzarra.com. Jimmy Choo pumps, $895; jimmychoo.com. On James Whiteside: Fendi shirt; fendi.com. Valentino pants; valentino.com. Dior boots; dior.com.

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Madonna, June 1990

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CENTER, NATALIE PORTMAN: CARLIJN JACOBS; FASHION EDITOR: MALINA JOSEPH GILCHRIST; HAIR: OLIVIER SCHAWALDER; MAKEUP: LUCY BRIDGE. RIGHT, FROM "LAST DANCE": RAHIM FORTUNE; FASHION EDITOR: NICHOLAS GRASA; HAIR AND MAKEUP: MARIYA PILTYEVA

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## PLEINE FLEUR

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REFILLABLE OBJECT

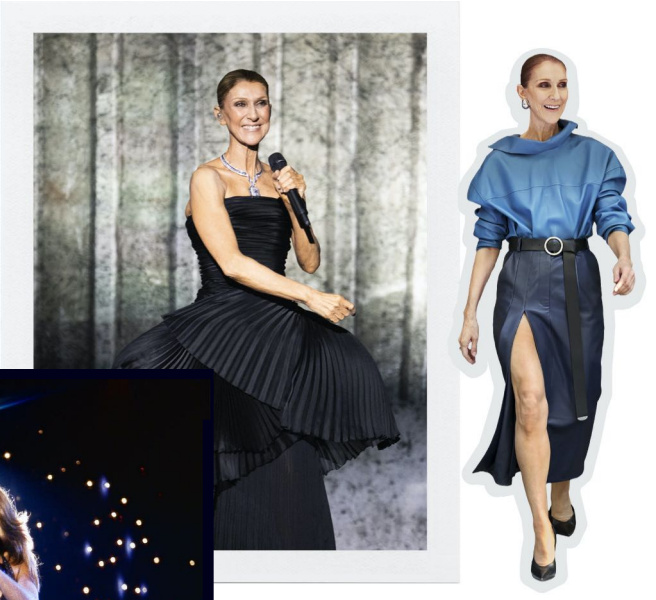
# WHY DON'T YOU...?

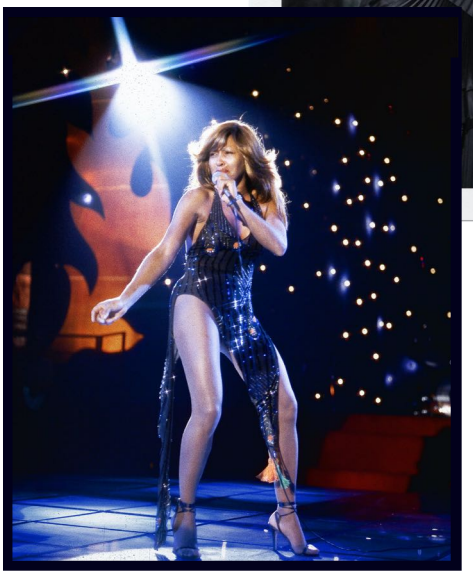
*Here's a* THOUGHT: *Don't get* DRESSED. *Mount a* PRODUCTION. *Put on a* SHOW. *Go on* TOUR. *And if the reviews are lukewarm, don't change the* COSTUME; *blame the* CRITIC! *For the* PERFORMANCE *issue,* LYNETTE NYLANDER *takes* CUES *from the stage's most* STYLISH *to arm you with* TIPS *for* STEPPING OUT.

**WHY DON'T YOU ... ADMIT** *that the "effortless" look took 40 minutes.* The "I just threw it on" leather jacket, the smudged eye makeup, the shirt that looks slept in: All of it is stagecraft. Miley Cyrus's new rock-star look personifies this. Never one to shy away from an "era," this one is all tousled hair, loads of lashes, and leather and lace from the likes of Tom Ford, Roberto Cavalli, and Saint Laurent. Effortless? No. Fabulous? Absolutely!

**WHY DON'T YOU ... MAKE** *some noise.* Taffeta rustles, silk whispers, embellishments jangle, and leather creaks with intent. Performance is not only visual. The swish of a skirt on a staircase is part of the entrance, and the weight of crepe hugging the hips is part of the walk. The late, great Tina Turner was a master of clothes that created a symphony as she writhed around the stage; often, they were the creations of the late, great Bob Mackie. Björk went viral earlier this year at the Venice Biennale in a neon-pink Bottega Veneta dress made of fiberglass shards that jingle-jangled together as she fist-pumped. The lesson? Dress for the ear as well as the eye.

**WHY DON'T YOU ... PRACTICE** *the precision of a uniform.* The chef's whites, the lawyer's suit, the professor's tweeds, the tailored black of the gallery assistant: Each is a costume designed with a very particular audience in mind. Even people who wear the same thing every day are making a statement, and the strongest of them curate that repetition with real rigor. Consistency, done well, is a kind of theater. Just don't make it boring! Consider Steve Jobs, who famous wore only Issey Miyake turtlenecks and Levi's. Truly the only tech titan to ever have taste!





Above: Céline Dion in Dior and Boucheron jewels (left) and a Fall 2026 Givenchy runway look

**WHY DON'T YOU ...EMBRACE** *the art of quick change.* For Céline Dion's fall residency at the Plénitude Arena in Paris, underneath the spotlight wasn't the only site where a performance took place. Like all true divas, Dion knows that every moment of every day is an opportunity to perform. Outside of the Royal Monceau hotel, her home in Paris, where her faithful fans lined up to greet her, she treated onlookers to a dance, a song, an air-kiss, and always a fashion show: off-the-runway looks from Jacquemus, Loewe, and Phoebe Philo. As they say, all the world's a stage.

Above: Tina Turner in 1979. Below: Kim Gordon in 1992. Left: Miley Cyrus in Celine at her album-release party earlier this fall.

**WHY DON'T YOU ... ALLOW** *the ordinary garment its moment.* Not every act needs sequins. A perfect white tee, a pair of jeans that have taken on the shape of a life, a forever leather jacket worn with confidence: these are the understudies who steal the show. Performance in fashion is not always about drama. Sometimes it is the quiet authority of a simple thing worn exactly right. A disciple of this way of dressing? Kim Gordon, whose effortless style, both on and off stage, has made her your favorite celebrity's favorite celebrity for the past 40 years. **HB**

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT: SAMIR HUSSEIN/WIREIMAGE; MEGA/GC IMAGES/GETTY IMAGES; GIE KNAEPS/GETTY IMAGES; KEVIN MAZUR/GETTY IMAGES FOR ATLANTIC RECORDS; ARTCO-BERLIN/ULLSTEIN BILD VIA GETTY IMAGES

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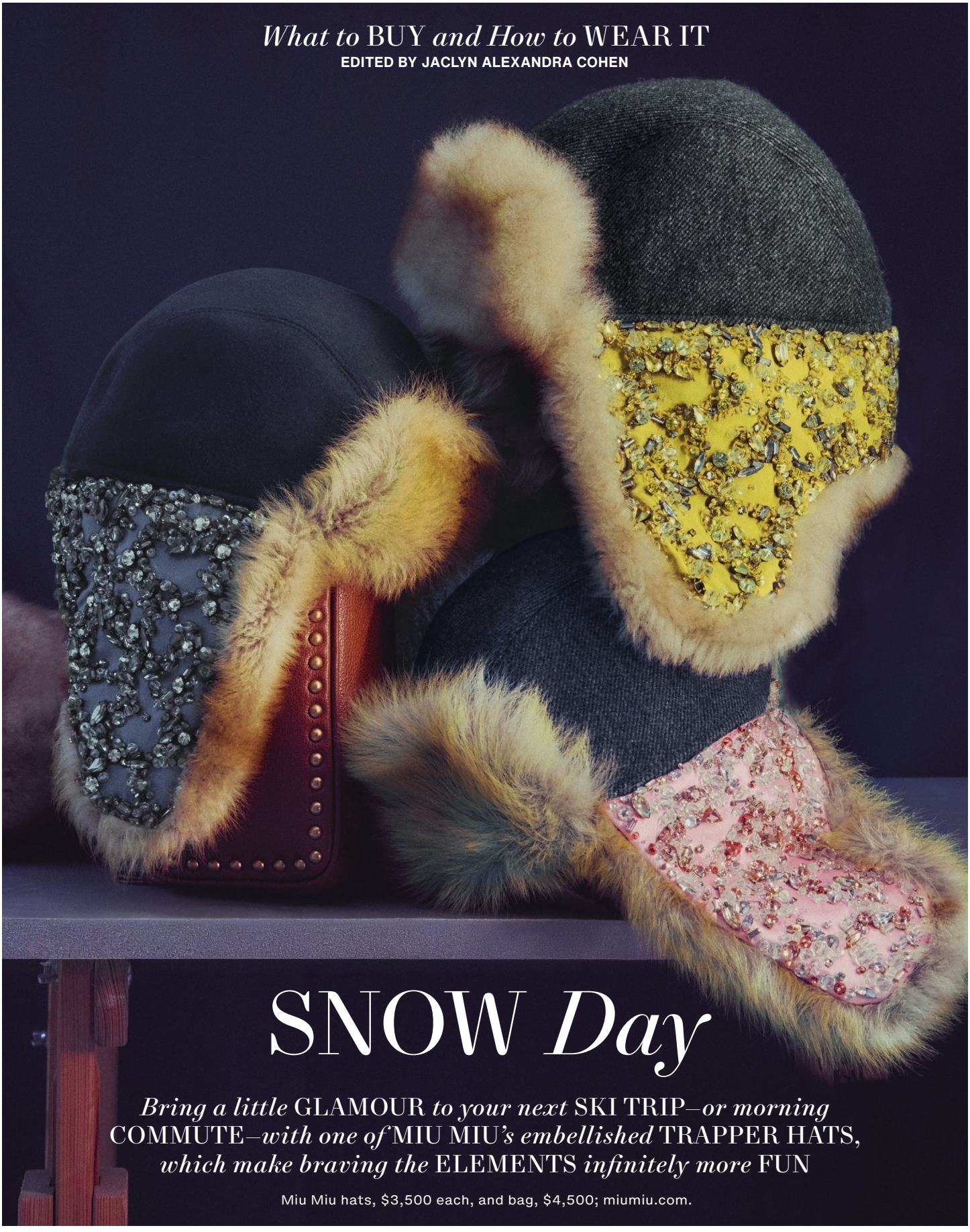

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PARIS

# WARM *Front*

**WHY DON'T YOU...?**
Upgrade the season's coat du jour for evening with FLAT BOOTS, LEATHER PANTS, and a STATEMENT HANDBAG.



Valentino Garavani bag; valentino.com.

Above, from left: Herbert Levine boots, $1,950; herbertlevine.com. Max Mara suede boots, $1,740; maxmara.com. Tory Burch boots, $595; toryburch.com. At right: Iro pants, $1,365; iroparis.com.

MIU MIU

ALTUZARRA

DIOR

Above, from top: Moncler jacket, $3,610; moncler.com. The Frankie Shop coat, $445; thefrankieshop.com. Saint Laurent by Anthony Vaccarello jacket, $5,100; ysl.com. Guess bomber jacket, $238; guess.com. Polo Ralph Lauren jacket, $598; ralphlauren.com.

FASHION EDITOR: JACLYN ALEXANDRA COHEN. MODEL: LAURA REYES; ALTUZARRA RUNWAY: ISIDORE MONTAG/COURTESY ALTUZARRA; ALL OTHER RUNWAY: LAUNCHMETRICS/SPOTLIGHT; THE FRANKIE SHOP JACKET: RICHARD MAJCHRZAK; ALL OTHER STILL LIFE: COURTESY THE BRANDS

# SUIT *Yourself*

HUGO BOSS

PROENZA SCHOULER

ANNE KLEIN

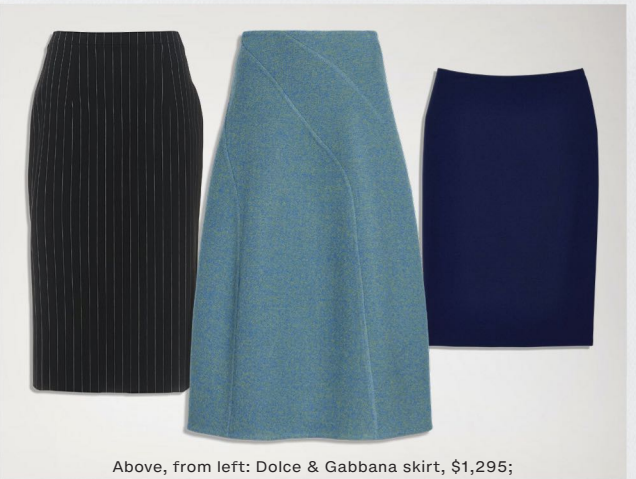
SCANLAN THEODORE

FROM LEFT: TOM FORD, RABANNE, CELINE, FENDI, MIU MIU, HODAKOVA, DOLCE & GABBANA, EMILIA WICKSTEAD

**WHY DON'T YOU...?**

Polish things off with a PUSSY-BOW BLOUSE and BOLD EYEWEAR for office-ready FLAIR.

At top, from left: Hugo Boss blazer, $599; hugoboss.com. Proenza Schouler jacket, $1,590; proenzaschouler.com. Anne Klein blazer, $139; anneklein.com. Scanlan Theodore blazer, $1,200; scanlantheodore.com. Above: Tom Ford glasses, $555; edwardbeiner.com.



Above, from left: Dolce & Gabbana skirt, $1,295; dolcegabbana.com. Proenza Schouler skirt, $1,290; proenzaschouler.com. Anne Klein skirt, $69; anneklein.com.

7 For All Mankind shirt, $398; 7forallmankind.com.

FASHION EDITOR: JACLYN ALEXANDRA COHEN. TOM FORD, CELINE, AND DOLCE & GABBANA RUNWAY: COURTESY THE DESIGNERS; ALL OTHER RUNWAY: LAUNCHMETRICS/SPOTLIGHT; ANNE KLEIN JACKET AND SKIRT: RICHARD MAJCHRZAK; ALL OTHER STILL LIFE: COURTESY THE BRANDS

Omega Speedmaster 38mm watch, $12,300; omegawatches.com. Saint Laurent by Anthony Vaccarello pumps, $3,600; ysl.com.

# *High* TIME

OMEGA*'s* SPEEDMASTER *gets a well-heeled upgrade with an* ICE-BLUE DIAL *and a dazzling* DIAMOND BEZEL *that elevates its* SPORTINESS *with some* SHINE

ACCESSORIES DIRECTOR: MIGUEL ENAMORADO. SET DESIGN: COLINE LE CORRE

# SAND *Lot*

*Swap out your dark* DRESS WATCH *for one in a* SOFT, DUSTY HUE, *with a tonal* STRAP *and a* DIAL *set in* WHITE GOLD *or* PLATINUM, *for an understated (and unexpected) touch of* WARMTH

At right: Patek Philippe Calatrava watch; patek.com.

Clockwise from top right: Omega De Ville Prestige watch, $5,500; omegawatches.com. Hermès Cape Cod watch, $3,600; hermes.com. Vacheron Constantin Overseas watch; vacheron-constantin.com. Baume & Mercier Clifton watch, $3,800; baume-et-mercier.com.

ACCESSORIES DIRECTOR: MIGUEL ENAMORADO. STILL LIFE: COURTESY THE BRANDS

# STROKE *of Genius*

BULGARI's *Violet Air masterpiece from the* ECLETTICA *high-jewelry collection draws on* MONET'S PALETTE *with an* IMPRESSIONIST GEMSCAPE *of radiant cushion-cut* KUNZITES, *cabochon* AMETHYSTS, *and green* TSAVORITES *that transforms a collarless* NECKLINE *into the ultimate* CANVAS

Bulgari high-jewelry necklace; 800-BULGARI.

ACCESSORIES DIRECTOR: MIGUEL ENAMORADO. SET DESIGN: VANESSA GIUDICI

# *The season's most striking new* JEWELS *and* OBJECTS *are* PLAYFUL, AUDACIOUS, SCULPTURAL, *and* SUBLIME

## HEARTS OF GLASS

Alessandro Palwer's enamel earrings feature Murano-glass cabochons, while Beck Jewels's Venetian beads read like candy and Sophie Bille Brahe's latest vases riff on the sheen of moonlit canals. Clockwise from left: Palwer earrings, $446; palwer.com. Sophie Bille Brahe Cellophane Ovale vase, $1,825; us.sophiebillebrahe.com. Beck Jewels Ancla necklace, $5,500; musexmuse.com.

## BRANCHING OUT

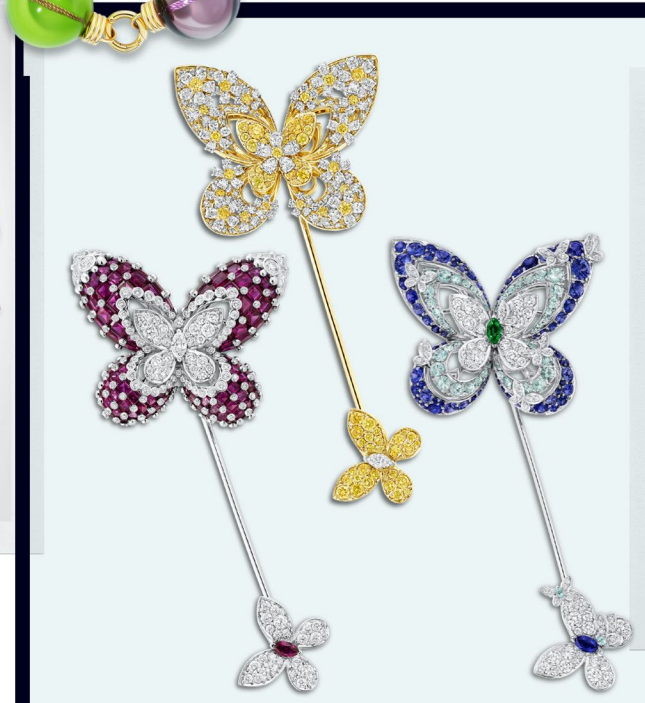
Dolce & Gabbana's high-jewelry brooch features a hand-carved angel perched on Mediterranean coral, and Brazilian designer Silvia Furmanovich has adorned blossoms with jadeite drops for her collab with Asprey. Left: Dolce & Gabbana Alta Gioielleria brooch; dolcegabbana.com. Above: Asprey x Silvia Furmanovich Jadeite collection earrings; asprey.com.

## MUSEUM-WORTHY

Sabyasachi celebrates centuries of craft in a new collaboration with New York's Metropolitan Museum of Art, evoking ancient treasures with pieces like a tiger-claw necklace with motifs inspired by *Casket With Erotes and Animals*. The Met x Sabyasachi necklace; 646-799-9400.

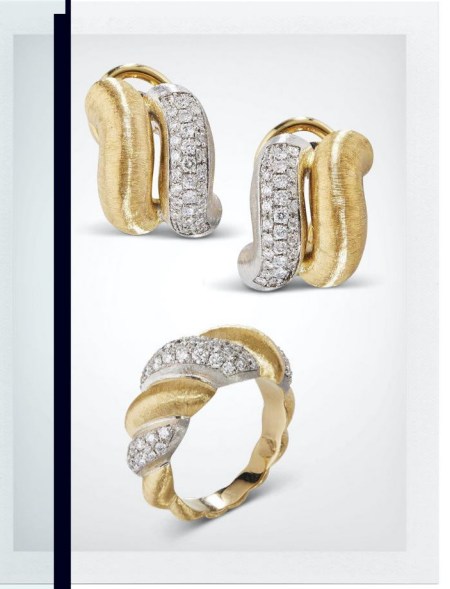
## MATCH POINT

Pasquale Bruni's Accendimi collection will spark joy with bold combinations of metals and gemstones, like black titanium capped in rose gold and pavé diamonds. Pasquale Bruni Accendimi ring, $2,580; us.pasqualebruni.com.



## BUTTERFLY EFFECT

Graff commemorates the 50th anniversary of a signature motif with a dozen one-of-a-kind high-jewelry brooches featuring wings that flutter beneath dazzling plains of gemstones as the body moves. Graff high-jewelry Butterfly brooches; graff.com.



## ARCHIVAL REVIVAL

Buccellati brings a fresh twist to its heritage Torsadé design with diamond-flushed ribbons of white gold that bring a rich contrast to buttery waves of yellow gold. Buccellati Torsadé earrings, $9,000, and ring, $7,500; buccellati.com.

ACCESSORIES DIRECTOR: MIGUEL ENAMORADO. STILL LIFE: COURTESY THE BRANDS

# *Double* TAKE

CHANEL's *new* FLAP BAG *combines elements from two of the house's most* ICONIC *styles—the* DOUBLE-C *clasp, the* MADEMOISELLE *turnlock, and the signature* CHAINS *from each—into a singular bag worth* COVETING

Chanel Flap bag; 800-550-0005.

ACCESSORIES DIRECTOR: MIGUEL ENAMORADO

Possession & Sixtie

PIAGET

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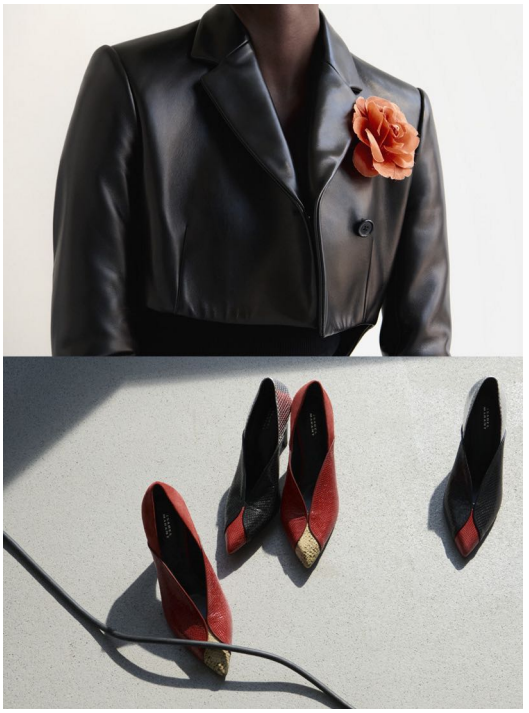
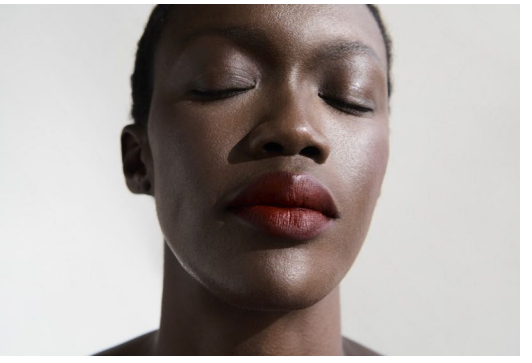


# RED *Alert*

## *The season's* STANDOUT SHADE *works best as a* RICH ACCENT *that transforms a low-key look into a* SHOWSTOPPER



At top left, from top: Khaite jacket, $7,800, and brooch, $440; khaite.com. Isabel Marant heels, $1,250; isabelmarant.com. At lower left, clockwise from top left: Willy Chavarria shirt, $650; willychavarria.com. Isabel Marant pants, $690; isabelmarant.com. Chanel top, $4,500, skirt, $6,450, belt, $1,250, and flap bag, $8,900; 800-550-0005. Celine sweater, $1,600, shirt, $990, trousers, $1,650, gloves, $660, and pouch, $1,000; celine.com. At top right, clockwise from top left: Tory Burch sweater, $595, shirt (both also pictured at right), $495, and skirt, $1,995; toryburch.com. Jude shoes, $630; thejude.com. Brunello Cucinelli trousers, $3,250; shop.brunellocucinelli.com. Jamie Haller shoes, $640; shop-jamiehaller.com. Dooney & Bourke bag, $498; dooney.com. Above: Dior Rouge Dior On Stage Lipstick in Red On Stage Matte, $48; dior.com.

FASHION EDITOR: JACLYN ALEXANDRA COHEN. MODEL: ADAMA JOBE; MAKEUP: LARAMIE FOR VIOLETTE FR; MANICURE: YUKO TSUCHIHASHI FOR NAIL HOLIC KOSÉ; CASTING: ANITA BITTON AT THE ESTABLISHMENT

PHOTOGRAPHS BY LOUIS DEWYNTER

# *Next* STEPS

*The defining* BOOT *for fall is* HIGH-HEELED, *comes in* SUMPTUOUS *leathers, and is endlessly* VERSATILE. *Wear it* SLOUCHED *with a skirt or* TUCKED *neatly under* TROUSERS.

Center: Phoebe Philo slouchy high boots, $3,000; phoebephilo.com. Far left, from top: Jimmy Choo boots, $1,750; jimmychoo.com. Ralph Lauren Collection boots, $1,890; ralphlauren.com. Manolo Blahnik boots, $1,675; manoloblahnik.com.

FASHION EDITOR: JACLYN ALEXANDRA COHEN. INSET BOOTS: COURTESY THE DESIGNERS

# LYNN NOTTAGE, WHITNEY WHITE, *and* JOHN LEGEND *are teaming up for a* NEW MUSICAL *that* RECLAIMS *an* AMERICAN CLASSIC *from a* BLACK PERSPECTIVE

In 2020, against the dual backdrops of the isolating Covid-19 lockdown and the righteous fury of Black Lives Matter protests erupting across the country, John Legend and Lynn Nottage began exchanging messages. Though the EGOT-achieving musician and the two-time Pulitzer Prize–winning playwright couldn't meet in person, the pair quietly became collaborators on a long-gestating project, now finally reaching the stage: a musical adaptation of *Imitation of Life*.

For nearly a century, *Imitation of Life*—which began as a 1933 best-selling novel by Fannie Hurst, became a John M. Stahl melodrama the following year, then was adapted for the screen again by Douglas Sirk in 1959—has been a cinematic fixture in Black American households, though not an uncontroversial one. Stahl's iconic telling centers on Bea Pullman, a white widow and single mother, who takes in Delilah, a Black single mother, as a maid in exchange for housing her and her light-skinned daughter, Peola (Sarah Jane in Sirk's version). When Bea boxes Delilah's family pancake recipe and puts a caricature of her likeness on the package—an unmistakable nod to Aunt Jemima—she becomes a wealthy businesswoman. But Delilah, content simply to care for Bea and her daughter, turns down any share of the money. Meanwhile, Peola, seduced by her adjacency to whiteness, wrenchingly disavows her mother to pursue a life of passing.

As Sterling Brown's scathing and influential 1935 review for *Opportunity: A Journal of Negro Life* made plain, the novel and film are mired in racist tropes. Yet despite its flaws, the story has continued capturing Black audiences, perhaps for the complex humanity clearly latent within Delilah's and Peola's characters. Now the story is being retold in a limited-run production opening December 3 at the Shed in New York, this time with a fully realized Delilah as the lead and an all-Black chief creative team at its core. Nottage wrote the book, while Legend—who also recently released his 11th studio album, *Muse*—composed the entire score. Whitney White, of *Jaja's African Hair Braiding* and *Liberation*, directs, with Adrienne Warren starring as Delilah and Jessica Vosk as Bea. Leading up to rehearsals for the show, Nottage, Legend, and White—so in demand that she was pulled into a production meeting midconversation—took time to discuss their own relationships to *Imitation of Life,* their experience working together, and why the story's themes remain as relevant as ever.

**LYNN NOTTAGE:** I come from a generation where both films, *Imitation of Life* from the 1930s and 1950s, were fairly ubiquitous on television. I ended up seeing the films probably once or twice a year and found myself in sort of a tense, love-hate relationship with *Imitation of Life,* in that I was frustrated by the treatment of Delilah and Peola in 1934, then once again by Delilah and Sarah Jane in the 1950s. And yet I was fascinated by the racial politics and this young woman who had a really angsty relationship with her own identity. So I felt, when I was invited to work on this, that I had an opportunity to delve deeper into the character of Delilah and right some wrongs. She is so fascinating; she's a mother, she's an entrepreneur, she's a woman who defies the expectations of the time. And yet throughout history, she has not been given her just deserts.

From left: Whitney White, John Legend, and Lynn Nottage

## *"It* REALLY DID *make me* THINK, *why* HADN'T *I done a* MUSICAL *before?"* JOHN LEGEND

**JOHN LEGEND:** I didn't grow up knowing this film, but my parents and their generation know it very well. So when I told them that I was involved in this musical, they were so excited. And it made me realize how important this work was in our culture. But like Lynn, it was a fun challenge to reimagine the storytelling, where Delilah was centered, her emotionality was centered, her humanity was centered, and Peola's humanity was centered as well.

And then, of course, I've never written a musical before. So part of the joy and educational experience that I've gotten from doing this is working with people who have so much brilliance and experience and understanding of a medium that I didn't bring to the table. It was the perfect introduction, for me, to writing a musical. It's been such a welcoming and edifying way to enter into this new branch of my career.

**NOTTAGE:** John is a natural in this medium. It's almost as if he had gotten a master's degree in musical-theater writing. I think that, John, you have so many musicals in you and the world is going to be blown away.

**LEGEND:** Thank you. It really did make me think, why hadn't I done this before?

**WHITNEY WHITE:** For me, I was raised by a single mom, and she raised me at great personal cost—spiritual cost—in Chicago, on her own. So the 1930s film, I oddly was more familiar with it because I liked it more. I would sit with my grandmother when she was having her coffee, like, at whatever-o'clock in the morning, because neither of us would ever sleep. And for some reason, I attached myself to the 1930s film. The visuals of that film are so iconic. It's like the foundation of Americana as it exists in global culture is visualized in that film. But also the story of Delilah echoes in so many ways. It's almost like touching a stove that's too hot for me. Because I've watched, my whole life, the world not see my mother in this way: her brilliance, her intelligence, her spunk, her grit. So I just knew that I could bring something to it. But I also knew that John and Lynn were going to give that character the eulogy and the eternal life that she's always deserved.

**LEGEND:** Yeah, I think because of Lynn's perspective and storytelling, we see other sides of Delilah. We see her being romantic. We see her being a brilliant businessperson, making a way out of no way—something that a lot of our ancestors, especially, had to do. They did what they had to do to realize the American dream.

**NOTTAGE:** At the core, this is a story about the American dream, with all of its contradictions and complications. It's a story about motherhood; it's a story about friendship, but it's also a story about passing. It's what we are forced to do to negotiate and survive in a world that is sexist, in a world that is racist. Why, in America, do we constantly have to make compromises in order to reach for the things that we desire? ➤

Those sacrifices, most often, people of color have to make, women have to make. We are often asked to reshape our identities to fit into some sort of template that's not necessarily comfortable for the shapes and forms of our bodies and our ideas and our identities. I think that's why we keep coming back to this story, because the struggle remains real.

**WHITE:** And I think, in the midst of having to constantly reshape our identities and bodies as Black folk, at the same time, we got the goods. We make culture. Here you have this character who saves this business, and what does she make? Delicious food that is worth millions of dollars. So while we're forced to be at the bottom of the totem pole, we also make the goods that make capitalism work. That's something I've really been sitting with: We're so often plundered and taken from the most, and yet we are the foundation of capitalism.

**NOTTAGE:** Can I ask you, Whitney, you're looking particularly luminous today. Where are you going?

**WHITE:** Girl, I'm sweaty. I just walked my child [to school]. My child is very heavy. I have this giant toddler; maybe he's going to be LeBron. He didn't want to walk to school, so he made me push him in his stroller.

**LEGEND:** I met your husband last week, so I see where he got it from.

**NOTTAGE:** I totally digress, but I was like, "Look at you, you have, like, a rosy green glow." [*Laughs*]

> *"This is a* STORY *about the* AMERICAN DREAM, *with all of its* CONTRADICTIONS *and* COMPLICATIONS." **LYNN NOTTAGE**

> *"The story of* DELILAH *echoes in so many ways. It's almost like touching a* STOVE *that's* TOO HOT *for me."* **WHITNEY WHITE**

**WHITE:** [*Laughs*] That beat that just happened is so beautiful because it's so indicative of the show. Like, we're talking about this heavy stuff, and then we all have this beautiful laugh. When I read the text and hear the music, it's like I go through 10 cycles of emotions. I laugh, I cry, I fall in love, then I laugh and cry and fall in love again.

**LEGEND:** One of my favorite things from the workshops is watching the music come to life. You have all these amazing performers embodying all the things that I wrote in my little piano room at home.

**NOTTAGE:** Theater is often so difficult and fraught to make because it is collaborative. I think one of the things that's been really lovely about this process is the ease with which we, as collaborators, are capable of having conversations, because there's so much mutual respect and appreciation. The bottom line in making a musical is that trust is necessary. It's a tremendous leap of faith.

**WHITE [*as she is pulled into production meeting*]:** I just want to add one last thing. Oh God, I don't want to get too emotional. Never in my wildest dreams did I imagine that I would be sitting here with two of my favorite living artists. When I started in this business, this kind of makeup for a musical team was impossible. I can't tell you how much pride and excitement that brings me, to be working alongside John and Lynn.

**NOTTAGE:** Thank you. We love you, Whitney.

**WHITE:** I'm going to go lovingly yell at people—lovingly, lovingly. Bye.

**LEGEND:** Our writing process started—we were meeting during Covid, so a lot of our first interactions were on Zoom. Lynn would send me pages with story dialogue and possible lyrical ideas. I would sit in my piano room and sketch out an idea with maybe a couple lyrics, but mostly just mumbling musical ideas around the theme.

**NOTTAGE:** I love the mumbles.

**LEGEND:** One of the things that happens more in musical theater than I'm used to is the revision process and the workshopping process.... I've definitely done more revision in this show than I've ever done in my pop-music career.

**NOTTAGE:** John, do you remember one of the very first conversations that we had? I said, "We're probably going to write that opening-number song at least 15 times." You're like, "Oh, I don't think so." Here we are!

**LEGEND:** Here we are. We've rewritten it multiple times. [*Laughs*] I don't have an extensive knowledge bank of musicals that I've seen and been a part of. So it was interesting, thinking about how to write for one, because part of it was like, "Well, let me just bring my own musical experience in the church and popular music and, you know, singing in a jazz a cappella group and singing show tunes in the choir in high school." I just brought my own experience and said, "Let me just write the songs that I can be proud of and that I believe will work." And then Lynn really taught me how to incorporate the storytelling into the songs.

**NOTTAGE:** It's so interesting to hear you say that, John, because I think one of the things that made the process so smooth is that you are a natural-born storyteller. There's something that you understand instinctively and fundamentally about dramaturgy that I didn't have to explain to you. I would venture to say that perhaps musicals are the hardest form of theater-making just because it is so layered.

But I also want to circle back to something that you said earlier, John, about the beginning of the process. It was Covid, and we were all thinking and making in isolation. There was something really lovely about reaching across the country to John and having these conversations about a book, even though we didn't really, at that point, know each other. We spent a lot of time talking about ideas. It was absolutely thrilling. When I got that first mumble, I was like, "Oh my God, it's John Legend mumbling, and it still sounds beautiful." It was a song that we never, ultimately, ended up using. I think that eventually you should do an album of the outtakes.

**LEGEND:** Yeah.

**NOTTAGE:** I just want to add, because we've been talking about some heavy themes, that the musical is not delivering spinach. The musical embodies all of the complexities of a beautiful woman like Delilah, a beautiful woman like Bea, a beautiful woman like Peola. It really is, in some ways, a celebration. It is a love letter. And it is a gift to be able to be in dialogue with these women. **HB**

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# *Stage* PRESENCE

## DEREK C. BLASBERG *talks to the incomparable* ALLISON JANNEY *about her highly anticipated return to* BROADWAY *and why she's made a career of playing* FORMIDABLE WOMEN *who refuse to* SHRINK

Allison Janney is famous for playing women who take up a lot of space. Fast-talking, tough-as-nails, frequently formidable women: C.J. Cregg, the White House press secretary turned chief of staff on *The West Wing;* LaVona Golden, the fur-coated, chain-smoking, bird-balancing nightmare of a mother turned antagonist in *I, Tonya;* and, most recently, Grace Penn, the vice president turned (spoiler?) president on *The Diplomat.*

In September, that last role earned Janney, 66, her eighth Emmy for acting, tying her with Julia Louis-Dreyfus, Cloris Leachman, and Jean Smart for the most performance Emmys in history. (She also has an Oscar, which she won in 2018 for *I, Tonya.*) She's six feet tall, a former dancer and figure skater, and statuesque in a way that has made her a red-carpet favorite.

Which is why I'm surprised when we take a stroll down New York's High Line, the elevated park on a former railroad track on the West Side that has become a top tourist destination, on a sunny, crowded afternoon and nobody seems to notice her. There are zero selfie seekers. No stares. No craning necks and whispers of "Was that … ?" One of the most decorated actresses working today is strolling through one of the city's busiest promenades undisturbed?

"The truth is, I'm a shy person," Janney says. On screens and stages, she's larger than life, but here in person, she very intentionally disappears into the scenery. Her off-duty look is determinedly incognito, with a beige jumpsuit, big sunglasses, and minimal jewelry, her blond hair half pulled back. "Maybe that's why I love playing these types of characters, which push me out there. Maybe that's who I wish I was," she offers. "A therapist would have a field day with me, huh?"

We descend to ground level and settle in for coffee at Cookshop, a restaurant in Chelsea. Janney is in town to prepare to become another "bawdy dame," as she puts it, in the new Broadway revival of Jon Robin Baitz's *Other Desert Cities.* The play centers on Polly and Lyman Wyeth (Julia Louis-Dreyfus and Ed Harris), a wealthy, prominent, politically conservative couple living in Palm Springs, California. Their daughter, Brooke (Lily Rabe), a novelist, comes home for Christmas with a memoir she's written about a painful chapter in the family's past, forcing the group, which includes Brooke's younger brother, Trip (Joe Keery), and Polly's sister, Silda (Janney), to reckon with it. What begins as a family gathering quickly becomes a fight over what really happened, what should remain private, and whose version of the past becomes the truth.

Through it all, Silda, a writer herself and a recovering alcoholic, emerges as the emotional conscience of the play. It's a complex role that requires a rare mix of wit and honesty to pull off, which is part of what attracted Janney to it. She had also worked with Baitz before. "He was actually the writer of one of the only episodes [in the first four seasons] of *The West Wing* that Aaron Sorkin didn't write," she says. *Other Desert Cities* originally opened on Broadway, where Janney first saw it, in 2011. "It's a brilliant play, and it's amazing how much it resonates today, because it's all about a family that's torn apart by grief and by politics," she says. "Especially the politics."

Politics has become an unexpected theme in Janney's career. Fun fact: Bradley Whitford, who played her deputy chief of staff, Josh Lyman, in *The West Wing,* now plays her husband, First Gentleman Todd Penn, in *The Diplomat.* (The show just kicked off its fourth season.) Did she ever dream of being a TV president? "No, never. It was huge that I became the chief of staff on *The West Wing*!" she remembers. "Even I was like, 'Are you sure?' " The day in 2024 when they shot the scene where her character on *The Diplomat* was sworn in was a surreal one. "Everyone felt emotional because the results of the last election had just happened," she recalls. "People were very upset that we chose *him* over *her.* Again."

The middle of three children, Janney was born in Boston. She moved with her family first to Cincinnati and then, when she was five, to Dayton, Ohio. Her mother had briefly been an actress and dancer; her father was a commercial real estate developer—and, fortuitously for his daughter, owned

THIS PAGE: COURTESY DEREK C. BLASBERG; OPPOSITE PAGE, CLOCKWISE FROM TOP RIGHT: MOVIESTORE/SHUTTERSTOCK; CLIFTON PRESCOD/NETFLIX; NBCUNIVERSAL VIA GETTY IMAGES

a building that housed an ice-skating rink. Janney spent much of her childhood there and dreamed of becoming a competitive figure skater. Her ambitions ended after a serious accident involving a plate-glass door when she was a teen.

When I tell her that I won't make her retell the story, she puts a hand on my shoulder and sighs, says, "Thank you," then looks to the sky: "Thank you, God!" But it's well known. When she was 17, at a party, she ran toward a sliding door she thought was open and crashed straight through it. Her right leg went through the pane; the falling glass came down on it like a guillotine, severing an artery and some tendons. At first, she was merely embarrassed—she told the band to keep playing—until she looked down to see her leg squirting everywhere. She lost an enormous amount of blood and nearly the leg itself, underwent skin grafts, and spent almost two months in the hospital. No more skates.

She enrolled at Kenyon College in Ohio in 1978 and studied theater history. Paul Newman, a Kenyon alumnus, had returned to direct a play inaugurating a new theater on campus. "Incredibly handsome and just divine" is the way Janney describes him. "A true movie star." She was cast and became friendly with Newman and his wife, Joanne Woodward. They encouraged her to pursue acting professionally. She moved to New York to attend the Neighborhood Playhouse actor's conservatory in 1982.

Above, clockwise from left: Allison Janney and Martin Sheen in *The West Wing;* in her Oscar-winning role as LaVona Golden in *I, Tonya;* as President Grace Penn, with her former *West Wing* costar Bradley Whitford, in *The Diplomat.* Opposite: The author with Janney on the High Line in New York.

WHAT FOLLOWED was considerably less glamorous: a decade and a half as a jobbing actress, doing tiny Off Off Broadway productions—"booger theater" is how she refers to it—while scooping ice cream in SoHo and working at a recording studio as she moved from apartment to apartment. "There were plenty of tears on the subway," she says. At one point, she became so convinced she should quit that she submitted herself to three days of aptitude testing, only to be told the career that best suited her: systems analyst.

Woodward would bring Janney into the Actors Group of New York—"a wonderful acronym," Janney notes: AGONY—which helped her secure representation. "Representation was always so hard. No one will come see you if you don't have an agent, but you can't get anyone to see you. It's a Catch-22," she says. "I got a manager, and things started working for me because of Joanne's dedication and her generosity in spending time with a bunch of out-of-work, nobody actors."

Newman was like a father figure. "He would say I had one favor, which I could cash in for anything," she says. "But I never used it, because I liked [having] it. I had a friend who'd always have a Valium in her pocket but never take it. She'd say, 'Just because I know it's there, I feel better.' That's how I felt about Paul Newman."

In 1996, Janney won a role in a Broadway production of the Noel Coward comedy *Present Laughter.* She was in her mid-30s at the time. After years of working, it was her breakthrough. "Other than playing Ginger on *Guiding Light,* the soap opera," she corrects. "I played a maid that wasn't good at her job. I gave her a Brooklyn accent, which probably wasn't a good idea. But I could pay my rent."

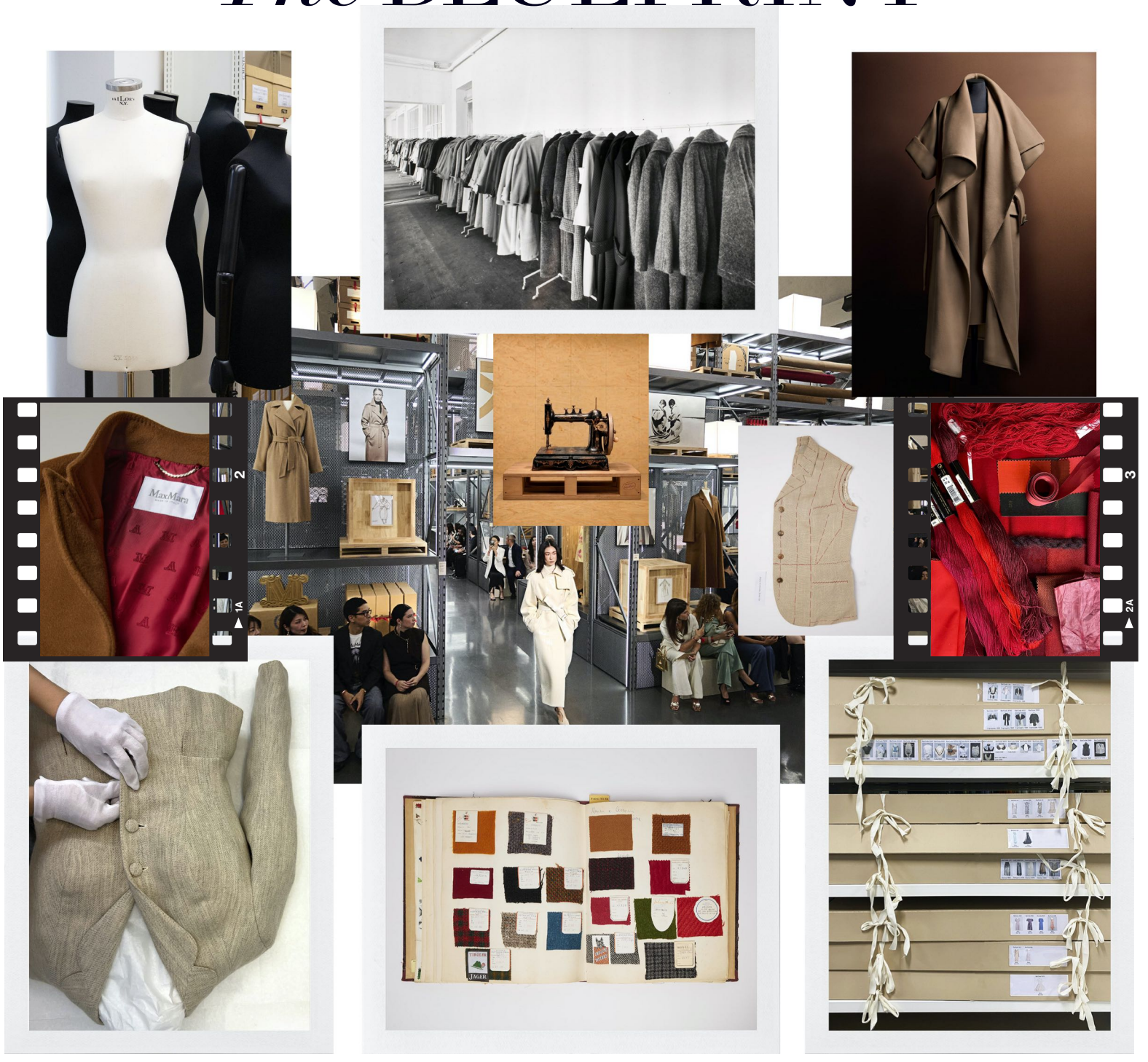
Aaron Sorkin brought Janney in to audition for *The West Wing* after seeing her in Mike Nichols's political satire *Primary Colors.* The show, which premiered in 1999, when she was almost 40, changed everything. She won an Emmy for Outstanding Supporting Actress in a Drama Series in the first season. "It was pretty spectacular because it was my first time being nominated—and unexpected. Who I thought should win was Nancy Marchand, who was in *The Sopranos* and had recently passed," she says. "Then they called my name, and I felt guilty and I felt excited all at the same time."

Tomorrow, Janney and her castmates in *Other Desert Cities* are back in rehearsals. It's Louis-Dreyfus's Broadway debut; everyone is wondering how their costar Joe Keery, of *Stranger Things* fame—he just finished a tour with his solo musical project, Djo—will affect the median age of the audience. "My entrance is something that's scaring me right now," Janney says. "I have to just come in and just own that space in a really wild way." In the script, I was amused by a two-word description of her character's vibe during the aforementioned scene: a mess. "She's not afraid to hold the floor, hold the room, walk in, and *own* it."

Turns out, Janney may not need a therapist. Playing these kinds of roles lets her work out a lot of things on her own. "I feel excited to get to say the things that C.J. Cregg got to say, the things that Grace Penn gets to say," she says. Her character in *Other Desert Cities* is a truth teller. "It's really empowering for me. I love it because I don't feel comfortable doing that. I identify with those kinds of women because I feel like I should be that kind of woman," she explains. "That's who I was meant to be." **HB**

FASHION *and* CULTURE

# *The* BLUEPRINT




*For* 75 YEARS, MAX MARA *has pioneered the* IDEA *that a foundational* WARDROBE*–what we wear to* MOVE *through the* WORLD*–is far from* BORING. *In fact, it can offer* ENDLESS POSSIBILITIES.

THIS PAGE, RUNWAY CLOSE-UPS: ARMANDO GRILLO/GORUNWAY.COM; FULL-LENGTH RUNWAYS: DANIELE OBERRAUCH/GORUNWAY.COM; ALL RUNWAY: COURTESY MAX MARA; OPPOSITE PAGE, TOP CENTER: STANISLAO FARRI; ALL PHOTOS: COURTESY MAX MARA

I STEPPED ONTO a crowded A train the other day, heading from Brooklyn to Manhattan, and was confronted with a microcosm of people with their different styles: contractors and construction workers (Carhartt and utility jackets), well-heeled, corporate pragmatists (slim suits, printed sheaths), fashion students (wearing their own creations), and art-world peacocks (prints on prints, layers atop layers).

There's no better way to get a sense of what people really wear than on a morning commute. If you drop in at 8:00 a.m. on the Paris metro, the tube in London, the U-Bahn in Berlin, Singapore's MRT, or the Shanghai subway, you'll see a tightly packed sardine can filled with disparate modes of nine-to-five dressing. But recurring motifs appear, particularly on those women who look like they've really got it together: a sleek camel overcoat paired with crisply creased trousers and a great T-shirt, or a pair of jeans and a sharply tailored black blazer. This is the no-fail, get-it-done-and-look-good-doing-it city uniform, and much of its history can be traced back to Max Mara, which celebrates its 75th anniversary this year.

This is why the brand, despite its Italian origins, chose to show its resort collection in Shanghai this past summer. "Max Mara has always been a metropolitan phenomenon," Ian Griffiths, the label's longtime creative director, tells me on the eve of the show. "After 75 years, that's what Max Mara is all about. It's about urban chic; it's about a woman who really wants to engage with a city." For Griffiths, just as modernity defines Shanghai, so too does it underscore Max Mara's longevity in fashion's rapidly shifting ecosystem.

The show was held at Shanghai's Long Museum West Bund, an art exhibition space housed inside a brutalist concrete building on the western side of the city. The skies that day were filled with dense gray fog and windy, misty rain, veiling the famously illuminated skyline just enough to look like a scene from *Blade Runner*.

"There's something about Max Mara that works really well against the background of brutalist architecture," Griffiths says. "It's like the city itself, and Max Mara's luxury is kind of a foil to this hard city landscape."

Above: Max Mara Resort 2027. Opposite page, center: Max Mara Resort 2027. All others, surrounding: "The Max!" 75th-anniversary exhibition and behind-the-scenes images shown at the Long Museum West Bund, Shanghai.

Outside the museum, an entirely new neighborhood was going up. Luxury apartment buildings, restaurants, and gyms were all being erected by clusters of giant cranes placed precariously close together. Inside the Long Museum, guests were time-warped back to Max Mara's beginnings in 1951, when Achille Maramotti founded the brand with one coat and one suit. He revolutionized sportswear in Italy by mass-producing classically tailored garments at a time when most men and women purchased their clothes directly from independent tailors and dressmakers. In many ways, Maramotti was an early proponent of modern sportswear and one of the first to translate it from its American origins to more distinctly European styles.

One of the most dominant themes on the runways in recent years has been this idea of wardrobing: effortless pieces that can be endlessly remixed, whether it's a jean and a blazer accessorized with a printed silk scarf, a boxy knee-length skirt suit, or a fluid dress made from cotton jersey. Juxtaposed with recent trends like heavy embellishment, texture, and eccentric shapes and silhouettes, these updated takes on classics offer a way to play with your personal style if the more idiosyncratic stuff isn't your thing. With Max Mara, though, it has never been about trends. Instead, the brand has held fast to the idea that real taste is inherent, not plucked from the internet, and that clothes should enhance rather than inform who you are or want to be.

It's why Max Mara has long appealed to women in power who need to be heard and armored. See: Nancy Pelosi in the fiery-orange coat she wore following a confrontational meeting with President Trump in 2018 or Meghan, Duchess of Sussex, looking poised and polished in white jeans and a cashmere camel trench in 2023, a look built to withstand public scrutiny. Katie Holmes said at the show that she loves Max Mara because of its "classic elegance" and its ability to "fit into any wardrobe." Fashion editor Tonne Goodman, who has styled many Max Mara shows and campaigns, is well known among fashion obsessives for her ➤

unimpeachable taste and rigorous uniform; she always wears some version of a chic silk scarf, sweater, and loafers.

"The clothes understand the realities of a woman's life today," says society fixture and designer Nicky Hilton, a longtime Max Mara client. "You can put on a beautiful coat or a perfectly tailored suit and immediately feel pulled together. But it never feels overly precious. The feeling of confidence and ease is incredibly consistent. The Teddy coats and camel coats have been staples in my closet for years."

Max Mara clients wandered the exhibition space alongside newer Gen-Z acolytes like Olympic freestyle skier Eileen Gu and filmmaker and actor Maude Apatow. Laura Lusuardi, who has been the house's fashion coordinator since the 1960s, was also there, dressed in a tunic, wide-leg pants, and sculptural statement jewelry. "Over 75 years, women's lifestyles have changed dramatically, and Max Mara has always closely observed and accompanied that evolution, especially through pivotal moments such as the rise of the 'working woman' in the 1980s," Lusuardi explains. "Our incredible archive serves as a constant source of inspiration, allowing us to rethink our heritage through a contemporary lens."

In tandem with the resort show, the brand staged an exhibition in the same space, curated by fashion historian Olivier Saillard, that re-created its archive in Reggio Emilia, Italy. The space was packed with floor-to-ceiling industrial shelving that featured wooden shipping crates, shoe and hat boxes, spools of thread, and historic ephemera from the Max Mara universe, including Maramotti's original sewing machines, advertisements dating back to the 1950s, and the original prototypes of some Max Mara coats. Through the archives, Saillard was able to highlight Maramotti's fashion origins as the son of a mother who wrote sewing manuals and great-grandmother who started a dressmaking school in the 1850s. "Within that origin lies everything fashion has to say: transmission, true elegance, the timelessness of a garment one makes oneself or holds dear," he says.

The show opened with a nod to streamlined glamour: a sequined ivory trench coat styled with a white turtleneck underneath and a pair of beige T-strap pumps. More monochromatic looks followed, including a boxy black miniskirt suit and a sumptuous white wrap coat cinched with a wide, decorative belt, which would appear in several playful iterations throughout the collection, including with black-and-white-striped sequined short shorts. Griffiths referenced the Bauhaus art and design movement (the original factory in Reggio Emilia was designed in a Bauhaus-inspired style) with dizzying graphic patterns applied to cardigans and pencil skirts, as well as injections of royal blue, mustard, and Max Mara's signature red.

The Shanghai collection was a reflection of Max Mara's unique ability to infuse newness and even some novelty (à la the short shorts, sequins, and belts) into its repertoire. As Griffiths explains, "It's about offering a curated choice that allows every Max Mara woman to find her style, her look, her silhouette." He adds, "Everyone has a desire for some kind of novelty, so you can't erase it from the offer, but within the context of a wardrobe or within a collection, there can be one or two pieces, and hopefully those pieces have longevity too."

Still, the aim, Lusuardi explains, is "not to be just 'in fashion'" but to "go beyond trends." She adds, "The essence of the Max Mara look lies in its essentiality."

After the show, walking back out through the exhibition space, you could see their points articulated: young women wearing their ivory silk button-downs and tailored pants with multiple layered belts in mixed metals; older clients dressed in vintage Max Mara skirts and jackets, styled with a cardigan over their shoulders or a decorative minaudière. The brand was all around, but you noticed the people in the clothes.

"Over the years, creativity in fashion has evolved into something tied deeply to personal style," Lusuardi explains. "It's how a woman wears and interprets a piece that truly makes the difference. Max Mara offers a versatile foundation that adapts seamlessly to every woman's unique lifestyle." In other words, there's no better—and more modern—uniform than one that's truly your own, whatever city or subway car you're making your way through. **HB**

Top row, from left: Michelle Yeoh, Maude Apatow, and Katie Holmes at the Max Mara Resort 2027 show in Shanghai. Middle row, from left: Gwyneth Paltrow and Alexa Chung at the Max Mara Resort 2026 show in Caserta, Italy. Bottom row, from left: Meghan, Duchess of Sussex in 2023 and Nancy Pelosi in 2018.

YEOH, APATOW, AND HOLMES: COURTESY MAX MARA; PALTROW AND CHUNG: GERMAN LARKIN; MEGHAN, DUCHESS OF SUSSEX: BACKGRID; PELOSI: DOULIERY OLIVIER/ABACA/SHUTTERSTOCK

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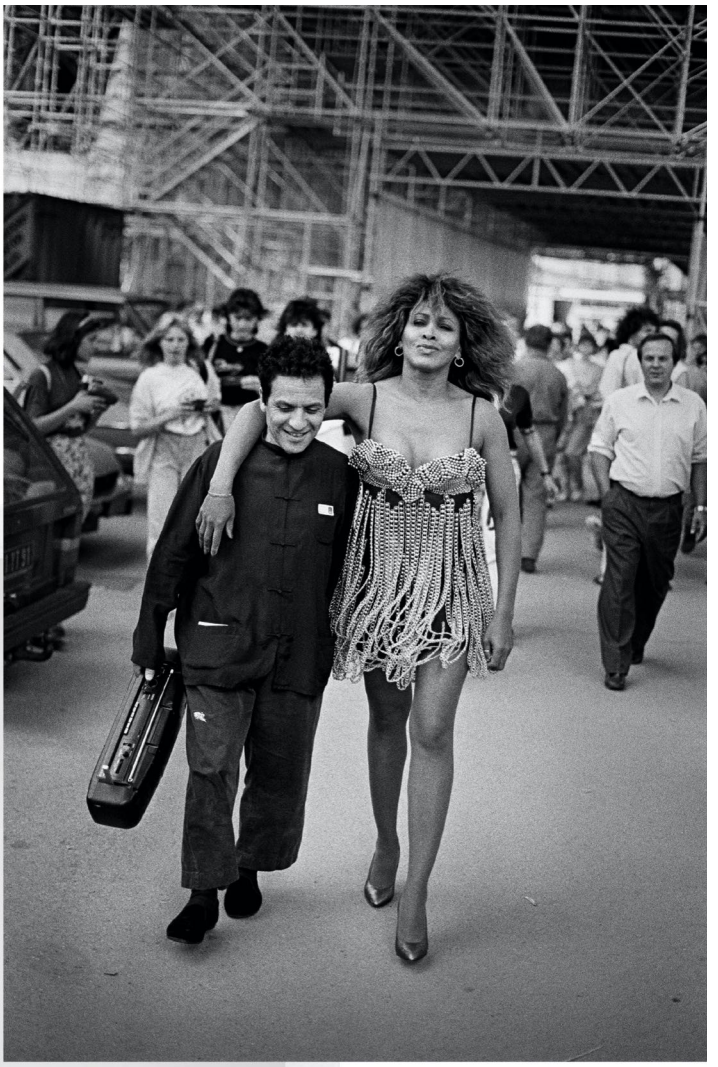
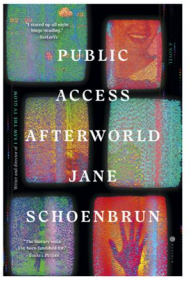
**"AZZEDINE ALAÏA: SCULPTING FASHION"** Opening November 21 at the Legion of Honor in San Francisco, the first major U.S. retrospective on Alaïa explores the legacy of the late Tunisian-born, Paris-based couturier, featuring garments from his personal collection. Once dubbed the "King of Cling," Alaïa designed second-skin creations that revolutionized fashion in the 1980s.



**SEIDLER JEWELRY LAUNCH** After designing for brands like Gabriela Hearst and Chloé, Benjamin Seidler is striking out on his own with his new eponymous line. Handcrafted in Italy, his pieces are at once romantic and architectural, including a fawn brooch, a tassel necklace, modular earrings, and a bow barrette.

**JIMMY CHOO'S PEARLS OF WISDOM** To mark its 30th anniversary, the London-based footwear and fashion brand is releasing a capsule collection featuring shoes, handbags, and jewelry centered on the pearl, which is deeply embedded in its history.

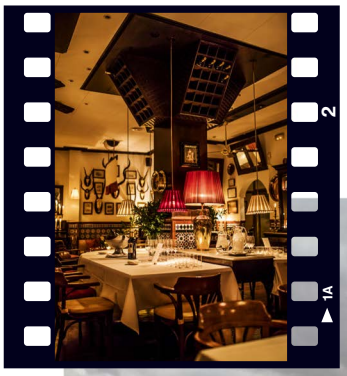
Above: Seidler Fawn tassel necklace, $790; seidler.co. Far left: Jimmy Choo Pearls of Wisdom Ithaca 95 pumps, $1,850; jimmychoo.com.




***PUBLIC ACCESS AFTERWORLD*, BY JANE SCHOENBRUN** The screen is a recurring motif in 39-year-old filmmaker turned author Schoenbrun's oeuvre. It plays its most central role in the director's 2024 film, *I Saw the TV Glow*, which uses the screen as an allegorical device to explore gender dysphoria, suburban isolation, and identity. "I had started to construct what felt like a language that I could use to speak about really personal things in a deep way, specifically this period of figuring out my own transness and beginning the process of transitioning," Schoenbrun says. Their debut novel, *Public Access Afterworld* (Hogarth), is an eerie, conspiratorial epic that expands on those themes and is structured like a 10-part TV series. The first "episode" follows David and Erin, two teens who discover a paranormal network. In the second episode, set 17 years later, we meet Bethany, a trans content moderator who encounters videos that seem related to the mysterious network and is drawn into unraveling its secrets. "David is very much a pretransition idea of self, the worst-case scenario of self," they say, "and Bethany is this idealized, heroic trans girl who is breaking through the boundaries of the screen." MAXWELL RABB

***PRADA IN THE NINETIES*, BY LAIA GARCIA-FURTADO** Few designer periods are referenced more than Mrs. Prada's transformative "ugly chic" work in the 1990s. Fashion heads, rejoice: A new book from *Bazaar* deputy culture director Garcia-Furtado, illustrated by Rachel Song, charts the impact of pre-Y2K Prada. "I've been training for this my whole life!" says Garcia-Furtado. (*Batsford*)

ALAÏA AND TINA TURNER, PARIS, 1989: PETER LINDBERGH, COURTESY THE PETER LINDBERGH FOUNDATION, PARIS; SEIDLER FAWN TASSEL NECKLACE: COURTESY SEIDLER; JIMMY CHOO SHOE: COURTESY JIMMY CHOO; ILLUSTRATION: RACHEL SONG FROM *PRADA IN THE NINETIES*, BY LAIA GARCIA-FURTADO, PUBLISHED BY BATSFORD; BOOK: HOGARTH



# *¡Vamos* ESPAÑA!

FROM TOP: COURTESY LA PARRA MADRID; JFK IMAGEN SOCIAL; COURTESY TABLAO DE LA VILLA; ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES; SALVA LÓPEZ; COURTESY CASA BEATNIK; BELÉN DE BENITO

From top: La Parra restaurant (restaurante-laparra.com); Solo Palacio hotel (solopalacio.com); flamenco at Tablao de la Villa (tablaodelavilla.com); Santiago de Compostela in Galicia (santiagoturismo.com); Cortana store in Madrid (cortana.es); Casa Beatnik Country House (casabeatnik.com); Faro Santander museum and cultural center (farosantander.com)

*With* SPAIN *fresh off a* WORLD CUP *win, there's no better time to visit* MADRID *and the cooler northern regions of* ASTURIAS *and* GALICIA

I lived in Spain in the early aughts, when the country was experiencing a mic-drop moment. The shiny, futuristic Frank Gehry–designed Guggenheim Museum had gone up in Bilbao a few years earlier, setting off what is now known as the Bilbao effect: a phenomenon that describes how investing in a visionary architecture project can transform a place. Food-obsessed travelers were flocking to a small beach town in a remote corner of northern Spain just to experience a meal at El Bulli, the legendary, now closed, three-Michelin-star restaurant headed up by Ferran Adrià.

Spain is now in the midst of another glow-up, thanks in part to its World Cup win, and Madrid is front and center. A recent influx of expats from South and North America has locals calling the city the "Miami of Europe." But don't let that dissuade you. Mallorquín designer Rosa Esteva, who designs the elegant, made-in-Spain fashion brand Cortana, emphasizes "the charm of those glorious old places that have survived through time." That means staying at hotels like the intimate **Hotel Orfila,** booking a table at **La Parra,** wandering through **El Rastro,** Madrid's legendary flea market, and checking out a late-night flamenco show at **Tablao de la Villa.** At the same time, contemporary places like Esteva's new shop in the Salamanca neighborhood, the modern tapas bar **Sala de Despiece,** and the contemporary-art gallery **Albarrán Bourdais** are worth checking out.

The typical Spanish itinerary often includes a few days in Barcelona to take in the Gaudí before heading south to the beaches of Andalusia. But Vella González, the founder of fashion brand Boxcalf, which has a flagship in Madrid's Malasaña neighborhood, extols northern Spain's charms and cooler climate. "For non-Spaniards, it's an undiscovered paradise," she says. Start in San Sebastián, one of the world's most celebrated gastronomic capitals, and eat your way through its pintxos bars, finishing with a steak at the Basque grill house **Portuetxe.** In Bilbao, discover the next generation of art spaces, such as the light-filled expansion of the **Bilbao Fine Arts Museum,** designed by Norman Foster and Luis María Uriarte. The Bilbao effect can be felt in nearby Santander, thanks to the new **Faro Santander** museum and cultural space, a historic building reimagined by David Chipperfield and currently showcasing the works of surrealist painter Leonora Carrington. Move on to the pristine beaches, green hills, and exceptional dining scene of the Asturias and Galicia regions. In Asturias, splurge on a stay at the remote wabi-sabi styled **Solo Palacio** and explore the old-growth forests and prehistoric rock shelters of **Las Ubiñas-La Mesa Natural Park.** Cozy up in the **Casa Beatnik Country House** hotel in Galicia, and walk the last 10 miles of the famed Camino de Santiago trail to **Santiago de Compostela** and its Old Town, a UNESCO World Heritage site. It's an idyllic ending to a new kind of Spanish pilgrimage. HB

TEXT BY GISELA WILLIAMS

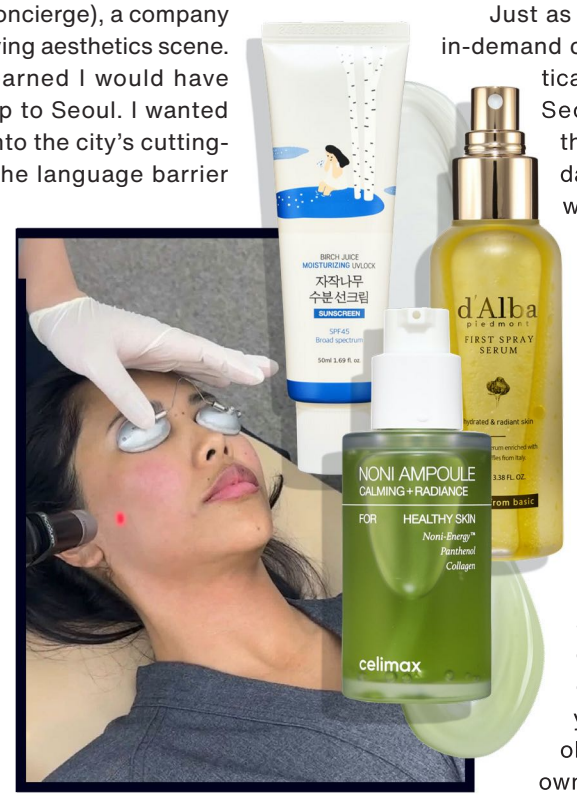
SHOPPING around for an AESTHETIC DOCTOR in SEOUL isn't as simple as finding a SHEET MASK or TONER. That's where CONCIERGES come in.

# *Beauty* BROKERS

It's a Friday night in Myeong-dong, Seoul's luxury shopping district, and I'm sitting on a matte-black couch, surrounded by a fluorescent digital installation with flashing blue and orange lights that read "Dr. Designer." I wonder: Does Dr. Designer claim that title because his *Black Mirror*–esque office is nestled between Loewe and Fendi or because he's kind of a couturier of faces? My eyes bounce back and forth between Dr. Designer (whose real name is Go Woong-jin) as he explains my skincare treatment options in Korean and Lynn Jang, who is translating for me into English. While this is my first encounter with Jang, my K-beauty fairy godmother while in Seoul, I've been in constant communication with her United States counterpart, Jennifer Seo, the founder of Aneue Concierge (@aneueconcierge), a company that helps Americans navigate Korea's dizzying aesthetics scene.

I first connected with Seo when I learned I would have about 12 hours of downtime on a work trip to Seoul. I wanted to use that time wisely by dipping my toe into the city's cutting-edge aesthetics offerings. But between the language barrier and overwhelming options, I didn't have a clue where to start. Seo and Aneue Concierge came highly recommended, so I reached out to schedule a call, letting them know I was interested in trying Rejuran, a skin-repairing treatment derived from salmon DNA that has since made its way stateside, but at a significantly higher price point than in Korea (and is not FDA-approved for injection). Instead, Seo recommended Re20, a new injectable skin booster derived from donated human dermal tissue. Within hours, I received a detailed schedule, which included a lymphatic massage, immediately followed by an appointment with Dr. Designer for Re20.

Ultimately, I did not go through with the Re20 injections; since my flight back to New York was a mere 12 hours later, the risk of swelling made it dicey, according to both Jang and Dr. Designer. I opted instead for just the lymphatic massage. On the tarmac waiting to take off the next day, I received a call from Seo to make sure I was satisfied with the experience. Working with Seo felt akin to the service you would receive at a five-star hotel—but for complicated overseas beauty procedures.




Above: Lee getting a treatment in Seoul. Concierge-approved K-beauty products, clockwise from top left: Round Lab Birch Juice Moisturizing UVLock Sunscreen SPF 45, $25; ulta.com. D'Alba Piedmont White Truffle First Spray Serum, $26; amazon.com. Celimax the Real Noni Energy Ampoule, $26; ulta.com.

SOUTH KOREA IS HOME to some of the most viral beauty trends, products, and skincare treatments to infiltrate the United States—but the technology overseas costs a fraction of the price. As a result, there's been a boom in beauty tourism in Seoul, with women using their savings and vacation days to stack everything from ablative lasers and facelifts to stem-cell harvesting and PDRN treatments in one trip. But these women, including celebrities like Kim Kardashian, aren't Googling dermatologists' offices or asking ChatGPT to schedule appointments—they're calling concierges like Seo.

The K-beauty appeal is part of a larger cultural fixation with Korean culture; everything from K-pop to Korean food has seen a surge in popularity over the last several years. "With the convergence of K-pop and K-dramas, which everyone listened to and watched during Covid, and then K-beauty causing beauty tourism to explode once Korea reopened in 2022, there's a high demand and volume for concierge services," Seo says. "But the big inflection point was in 2024, when the second wave of K-beauty hit, and it's been continuing to increase from there." After 15 years of traveling to Korea for personal trips and to visit family, Seo left her career in finance to start Aneue Concierge in 2019, and the business has grown beyond her expectations.

Just as for a top-tier travel agent, finding in-demand concierge services is more sophisticated than a simple internet search. Seo's K-beauty clients often come through word-of-mouth recommendations, which is how I found her. We were connected by makeup artist Nam Vo, who has four aesthetics trips to Seoul under her belt and has worked with Seo.

"It's about convenience and access," Vo says. "I also don't want to be herded into a factory clinic like a sheep. I might be cheap about other things, but not my face, and I use a concierge because I know the doctors are vetted."

This distinction is important, as factory clinics—high-volume assembly-line-style medical centers—are like the fast fashion of aesthetics, but riskier. "A few years ago, clients would have been okay to navigate the scene on their own, but now clinics know foreigners are coming, and with money to spend, so there's a bigger opportunity to be upsold or to be convinced to do something you don't necessarily need or want," Seo explains.

Erin An, who is based in Hong Kong and runs K-Beauty Concierge (@k_beauty_concierge), with a team in Seoul, says that with the vast number of practices, it's no wonder some beauty tourists fall prey to shoddy procedures, unnecessary treatments, or being overcharged. "There are more than 7,000 clinics in Korea, so it can be overwhelming to determine which doctors are both trustworthy and right for your individual needs," she says. "Many clinics also use aggressive social-media marketing, making it easy for international patients to choose a clinic that may not be the best fit." Plus, most clinics' websites are not in English and lack transparent pricing. An ensures that clients are charged "the same standardized prices they charge other patients, so there are no hidden costs or markups."

In a world where so many turn to chatbot travel itineraries and beauty recommendations, beauty and aesthetic recommendations call for a human touch. Carmella Vong, a San Francisco–based ➤

OPPOSITE PAGE, MODEL: YEJIN SUNG AT ONE MANAGEMENT; THIS PAGE, CENTER: COURTESY VANESSA LEE; STILL LIFE: RICHARD MAJCHRZAK

marketing manager at OpenAI, worked with Seo for her recent trip to Korea. "Jennifer is the source of truth," Vong says. "I wanted to do Ultherapy, and she was like, 'I don't know if you need that yet.' I love that she's blunt with me." Vong went into the trip with a laundry list of treatments she wanted to try, but Seo helped her workshop it to best fit Vong's goals, budget, and trip length.

The introductory call is the first step for concierges like Seo and An, who will go over every logistical detail, like budget and aesthetic goals. From there, the concierge takes care of everything, delivering a full itinerary with times, addresses, and pricing and staying in constant communication throughout the trip. Some concierges, like Seo, can even help arrange private drivers, dinner reservations, and tourist excursions. "We coordinate the full Korean experience, complete with hidden spots and local favorites," she says. "If a client wants to do a shopping tour or food-and-wine tour around Seoul, then we have guides who can assist with that on non-skincare days."

Finding the right doctor is only half the battle; recovering overseas is the other. "For surgical cases and particularly when clients are traveling alone, our team provides on-the-ground support to ensure that the client is properly assisted and settled during the postoperative recovery period," An says. In my case, an on-site liaison was with me the entire time to help with the language barrier and answer any questions. At Aneue Concierge and many other agencies, a client manager is included in the service. "Our client manager will be with you at every appointment to make sure the doctor is doing exactly what you're comfortable with and to prevent you from feeling pressured," Seo says. If you have a reaction to a procedure, the handler can get you back into the doctor's office or coordinate medication. "It's not one and done," Seo adds.

Above: Vong receiving an IPL face treatment in Seoul. More beloved K-beauty formulas, clockwise from top: Fully Rice-Dough Modeling Mask, $22; amazon.com. Dr. Reju-All Advanced PDRN Rejuvenating Lip Serum, $14; ulta.com. MDP+ Red Lacto Collagen Wrapping Mask, $25; amazon.com.

ASIDE FROM THE FACT that having a hand to hold (both figuratively and literally) while you get a deep-plane facelift is comforting, concierge services often provide a more reliable way to find reputable doctors and clinics, as legal cases related to aesthetic treatments in Korea have been on the rise. In 2021, popular Korean influencer Kim Min-young, who goes by the name Aori on social media, shared photos of bruising and complications following a "health injection" and was sued for defamation by the clinic, which reportedly sought more than $900,000 in damages. (While the case against Aori was dismissed last year, her ex-husband was reportedly ordered to pay damages for criticizing the clinic on social media.) While you can often take a Google review at face value in America, reviews of Korean clinics are skewed because the law considers any negative public statement—regardless of its veracity—to be defamation. Concierge services and their human touch can provide a trustworthy source to help navigate a murky digital landscape.

Vanessa Lee, a Los Angeles–based aesthetic registered nurse and the founder of the med spa the Things We Do, has been to Seoul three times for both business and pleasure. On top of her extensive knowledge, she has enlisted An to help source clinics and treatment options. "Why I really love Erin is she's ethical and does things by the book," Lee says. "She also has a mix of more-well-known doctors that are on social media and then deep-cut doctors who you have to know someone to get into their office. By working with Erin, I found practices I would never have heard about otherwise."

While full-service and hands-on, concierge services like these are surprisingly accessible in the grand scheme of skincare aesthetics. Some concierges set a fixed rate, like Seo, who charges a base price of $1,500 for a package of services; others, like An, don't charge the client and instead share a portion of a clinic's revenues as a courtesy for bringing in clientele. "Most of our partner clinics are boutique or privately operated practices that may not have large international marketing teams, so we add value by helping them connect with international patients and supporting those patients throughout their experience," An explains. Vo warns that some concierges coordinate with doctors and clinics to receive a kickback under the table, so it's important to do thorough research before agreeing to work with one.

"Not all clinics are created equal in Korea, so you have to do your due diligence as a consumer," Lee says, adding that one should check how long the concierge has been in business and how often it has been physically in Korea if it's based elsewhere. "If a website has nonstop flashing specials everywhere, it's probably not a good sign," she adds. "But if you try and book an appointment and there's nothing open in the next few weeks, that's a healthy sign that they are sought after."

But the most sought-after Korean aesthetics concierges aren't just connected to world-class doctors. At the end of the day, they are sympathetic, warm, and human in a situation that is clinical and has real risks attached. "You're not only working with doctors, but you may go under a knife, and there are needles involved; it's so helpful to have someone that you trust, who has experience being in a medical environment and can act as a translator," Vong says. "After my friend and I got Botox and Sculptra injections, Lynn came to lunch with us. We dragged her along with us the rest of the day. It was so fun." HB

CENTER: COURTESY CARMELLA VONG LEE; STILL LIFE: RICHARD MAJCHRZAK

# MODERN *Classics*

Perfumes are living art. Fragrance formulas change in subtle ways from year to year due to ingredient and industry regulations, and decades of tweaks take their toll. Eventually, a scent like perfumer Edmond Roudnitska's Diorama, a spicy floral chypre from 1949, hardly resembles the original. That was the inspiration behind Dior perfume creation director Francis Kurkdjian's ambitious new restoration of 13 of Dior's heritage fragrances, which captures the authenticity of each through a contemporary lens. The Diororiginals collection took four years to meticulously complete, a feast for fragrance and history nerds alike. "It's the opposite of a facelift," Kurkdjian jokes. HB

From top: Christian Dior Parfums Dioriginals eaux de toilette in Diorling ($155), Higher ($142), Diorama ($155), Diorissimo ($155), Higher Energy ($142), Eau Fraîche ($155), Dune Pour Homme ($142), Dune ($155), Forever and Ever ($155), Jules ($142), Dolce Vita ($155), Diorella ($155), and Dioressence ($155); dior.com.

# *Character* STUDY

## NATALIE PORTMAN *on* ART *(a new movie!)*, MOTHERHOOD *(a new baby!)*, FAME *(a new outlook!)*, *and the* FREEDOM *that comes with* CHOOSING JOY

Story by LEAH CHERNIKOFF
Photographs by CARLIJN JACOBS
Styling by MALINA JOSEPH GILCHRIST

It's just after 9:00 a.m. on a weekday morning on Rue Debelleyme in Paris's Marais district, and Natalie Portman is posted up against a wall in a black T-shirt dress that tents over her pregnant belly. A Dior tote bag is slung over her arm. It's mid-June, warm but not heat-wave warm (yet). We're meeting today, well in advance of her films coming out this fall and winter, because Portman plans to spend the summer preparing for the birth of her third child, who will arrive at the end of August.

She is somehow the only person on this tiny street, and it is strange to see a star of her magnitude in plain sight. I expect an entourage of paparazzi to pop out, but none do. It is one of the reasons Portman has called Paris home for the last decade.

"When I was pregnant in New York and L.A., I was followed by 20 men every day," she tells me later. "There's so much interest in pregnant women in particular. I'd never been bothered more. And here, they know, and I've been almost completely left alone."

With this pregnancy, though, public fascination won out over French discretion and decorum. The father is Portman's newish partner, the French electronic musician and producer Tanguy Destable. Portman, who is now 45, split from her ex-husband, the French dancer and choreographer Benjamin Millepied, in 2024, after 11 years of marriage. The former couple share two children, Aleph, 15, and Amalia, 9.

These are the kinds of not-particularly-out-of-the-ordinary life occurrences that become extraordinarily interesting if you are as famous as Natalie Portman. A few days before this story goes to print—which is a few weeks after Portman welcomes her new baby—she tells me that she is "full of wonder and joy at this magical little human." She adds, "It gives me a whole new attention to my big kids too, as I am reminded of how recently they were these little fresh creations and how quickly they've blossomed into incredible humans with their own amazing personalities and senses of humor and ideas."

PORTMAN HAS ARRANGED for us to visit the Thaddaeus Ropac gallery to see "Earthsongs," the 86-year-old American painter Joan Snyder's first solo exhibition in France. We wander through the gallery before it's open to the public, taking in Snyder's large-scale abstract canvases and lush landscapes. When you lean in, you can see bits of dried flowers, seed pods, burlap, and straw embedded and suspended in the clumps of paint.

We debrief over breakfast at a nearby Swedish café that is awash in light wood. She orders tea and some kind of oatmeal situation in perfect French, despite downplaying her fluency, and we settle in at a corner table. Portman's dark-brown bob is parted down the middle and pulled into a low ponytail framing her bare face—an exquisite arrangement of upturned eyes and high, sculpted cheekbones.

It might seem a bit on the nose to go to a gallery before discussing her latest film, *The Gallerist,* which is out December 4. The film is an art-world satire in which she stars as the high-strung, icy-blond titular gallerist alongside Jenna Ortega, Catherine Zeta-Jones, Da'Vine Joy Randolph, Sterling K. Brown, and Zach Galifianakis. Set at sceney Art Basel Miami Beach, *The Gallerist*'s absurdist plot hinges on a *Weekend at Bernie's*–style twist in which Portman's character, Polina Polinski, helps instigate a ➤

*Coat,* DIOR. *T-shirt hat,* GIVENCHY BY SARAH BURTON. *Bird on a Rock by Tiffany pendant,* TIFFANY & CO.

*Dress,* SIMONE ROCHA.

bidding war over a corpse (Galifianakis). She assumes she will be able to pull it all off because the artwork (the dead body) will be stashed away in a free port, a tax-free haven where the .001 percent hides their billions in the form of artwork.

It was hard for Portman to wrap her head around this kind of artistic exchange; it's not the way she consumes art or how she thinks about her own work. "I'm used to just going to a museum or a gallery and seeing art and enjoying it, and that's the transaction," she says. "To understand that there's people who literally have hedge funds that essentially turn these pieces from someone's soul into a bar of gold that can be traded and stored and hidden away—and no one sees it, and then no one experiences it, no one interacts with it—emotionally was really wild."

Portman comes by her own love of art honestly. "My mom is a fine artist," she explains. "She took me to see art a lot as a kid. Actually, I made my first movie, *The Professional,* here, and she used to take me every weekend when I was shooting to go see art. I remember one of my favorite things was going to the Rodin Museum with her. Then she got clay and we would come home and do sculptures afterward."

## "*People always* THINK *I'm a* PERFECTIONIST. *I'm the opposite. I'm* FORGIVING *with* MYSELF."

*The Gallerist* is a different kind of role for Portman, a departure from her more intense, dramatic stuff, and it allows her to flex her latent comedic chops. Her character is self-serious, gives off nervous-hamster energy, and teeters around in an all-black gallerina uniform and platform heels.

"Natalie has these insane nails in the movie," the film's director, Cathy Yan, tells me. "We had professionals that came in to do her nails, and every day one of the nails would fall off. She could not keep them on. I don't think in real life she's ever had long nails. So it was fun to see her stretch herself. She got to be a little bit bigger, a little bit more showy, a little funnier, certainly campier than a lot of her previous roles. It was funny to see the tension between who Natalie really is and this outlandish character."

PORTMAN HAS SAID she thinks of her career in phases. There was what she calls the "long Lolita phase," consisting of roles that often dealt with violent and disturbing themes, which marked the beginning of her career. She started, famously, at age 12 with *Léon: The Professional,* Luc Besson's 1994 cult film, playing the streetwise Mathilda, who is taken in by a hit man with a heart of gold (Jean Reno) after her entire family is murdered. In 1995's *Heat,* Portman plays Al Pacino's troubled stepdaughter; there is a gruesome scene where Pacino pulls Portman's lifeless body out of a bathtub filled with blood following a suicide attempt. And in retrospect, the relationship between Portman's 13-year-old character in 1996's *Beautiful Girls* (she was 14 during filming) and her 28-year-old neighbor, played by Timothy Hutton, in town for his 10-year high school reunion, is flirtatious and creepy.

Portman was born in Jerusalem to an Israeli father and American mother and moved to the U.S. when she was three. She grew up in Syosset, Long Island, which she has described as "classic American Jewish suburbia." Her father, a fertility doctor, also practiced in nearby Manhattan. Portman loved theater; when she was scouted by a modeling agent after a dance class at age 10, she told the agent she'd rather act. *The Professional* was Portman's first screen credit, but in 1992, Portman and Britney Spears were both understudies for the same part in an Off Broadway show called *Ruthless!*

In response to the overly mature nature of her early film career, she and her parents made sure that her real life was buttoned up. (On red carpets, she wore outfits that were modest and age appropriate, and she maintained good grades at school.) "I think there was a conscious effort, because I was depicted as this sexualized Lolita," she says, "that I wanted to be like, 'No, I'm serious, I'm a good girl, I'm a prude, I'm smart, I'm a student,' emphasizing that as almost a safety mechanism." Just as she was reaching peak starlet age, Portman went to Harvard, graduating with a degree in psychology in 2003.

Portman has characterized the next phase of her career as "chick who helps the guy realize his emotional thing," into which you would slot 2004's manic pixie dream girl ur-text *Garden State* and Mike Nichols's *Closer.*

*Black Swan* is sort of the inverse of this category. Portman won an Oscar for her work in Darren Aronofsky's 2010 psycho-sexual ballet thriller, in which she plays a ballerina so desperate to please the company's artistic director that she loses her grip on reality. Apart from a few exceptions (the sorely underrated rom-com *No Strings Attached* and the requisite Marvel role in the *Thor* series), *Black Swan* paved the way for a phase filled with more critically acclaimed work playing to Portman's strength in portraying a rich interiority, especially Jackie Kennedy in 2016's *Jackie* (which earned her another Best Actress Oscar nomination) and Elizabeth in Todd Haynes's *May December* in 2023, opposite Julianne Moore.

"But then, over time, it became like everyone thinks I'm really serious," Portman reflects. "I'm very silly, and I love to laugh more than anything, and I love to goof off. People always think I'm a perfectionist, I think, because of *Black Swan.* I'm the opposite. I'm forgiving with myself. In college, we had a phrase: 'Done, not good.' "

A lot of Portman's life in the public eye, which has been most of her life, has seemed to be about pushing against expectations that have been thrust upon her. There was, iconically, "Natalie's Rap" back in 2006, a few years after she'd graduated from Harvard, where she went all-in rapping on a *Saturday Night Live* digital short (Sample lyrics: "All the kids looking up to me can suck my dick / It's Portman, motherfucker, drink till I'm sick"), and then she revived the act in 2018 ("Tide Pods the only fucking thing I snack on / Black out and go motherfucking *Black Swan*").

Now, maybe, Portman is at an age where she can just be. She also served as a producer on *The Gallerist.* The film was shot in Paris, so she would host the cast and crew at her home for dinner. "Natalie is a vegan. She's got three dogs. And you go to her place in Paris and there's just dog hair everywhere," says Yan. "It's just so human, and I love that about her, and it's not maybe necessarily how you would picture her. But that's how I think of Natalie."

I ask Portman how she would describe this current phase of her career. "Right now, it's a lot of joy," she says. "I think it's both for ➤

*This page: Cape and dress,* CELINE. *Bird on a Rock by Tiffany Wings earrings and rings,* TIFFANY & CO. *Tights,* FALKE. *Sandals,* DIOR. *Opposite page: Dress,* GIVENCHY BY SARAH BURTON. *Sunglasses,* JACQUES MARIE MAGE.

myself and what I hope to offer an audience, because it just feels… I mean, every time has dark moments, but it feels like there's a lot of really heavy stuff going on. It's just ever-present in our face, and so it does feel like the biggest service you can do right now as an artist is to deliver some joy."

PORTMAN HAS SAID that because of her petite stature and how long she's been working, people still often treat her like a child, pat her on the head even. It probably doesn't help (or hurt) that she still looks, when I'm seated across from her, like Queen Amidala or Nina Sayers or Sam from *Garden State*. "I mean, I'm 45. I'm fully nowhere near being a child anymore," Portman says. "Just being small, I think a lot of people relate to you differently. I think that that compounds the issue too when you have been a kid actor."

It's an experience Portman's *Gallerist* costar Jenna Ortega—a fellow diminutive former child actor—deeply relates to. "It can be a little bit jarring because people speak at you differently," Ortega says. "And I think maybe that is the key word, speak *at,* especially if they get to know you as a young performer at first, because I think it's really hard for people to get over that and no longer infantilize you or speak to you like you don't know what you're talking about." Working alongside Portman showed Ortega that "one, I'm not alone in this," and then "two, well, if she's still dealing with this, this is something that is just going to be a part of my life, and I have to accept that and do what I can to still be comfortable with taking up my space."

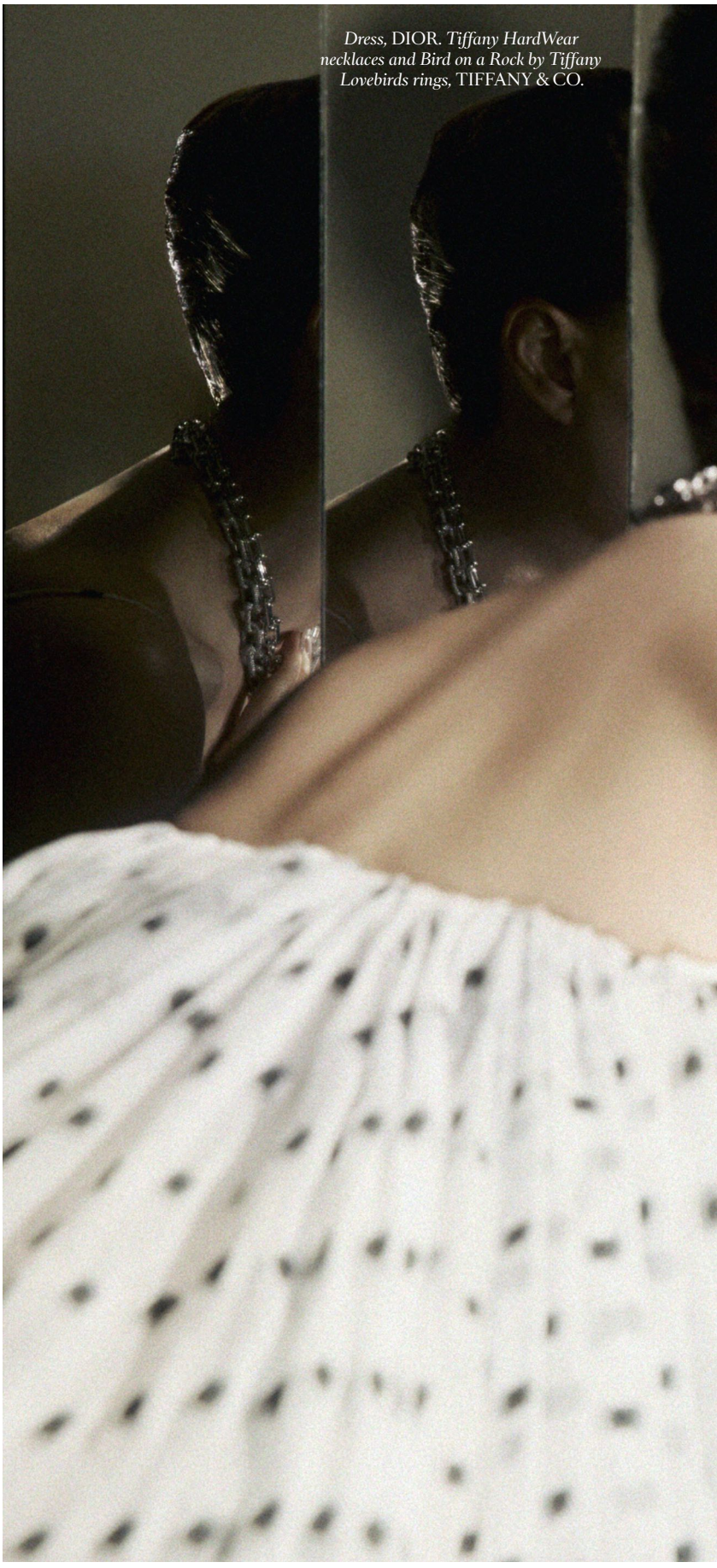
More recently, Portman has seemed open to revealing a bit more of her unguarded self. Outside of the Spring 2024 Dior couture show, in a viral clip caught on social media, Rihanna and Portman gushed over each other in mutual adoration, with Rihanna telling Portman that she is "one of the hottest bitches in Hollywood forever" and Portman replying, "I'm going to black out." She later told Jimmy Fallon on *The Tonight Show,* "I think every woman going through a divorce should get to have Rihanna say to her that she's a bad bitch.… It was a formative moment in my life."

Last year, Portman pranced onstage at Madison Square Garden in tiny jean cutoffs as one of Role Model's "Sallies" as he performed his hit "Sally, When the Wine Runs Out." (Other Sallies have included Charli XCX, Olivia Rodrigo, and Bowen Yang.)

"I'm a very simple person," Portman tells me. "I just want a word game, a cooking-competition show, a good meal, and I'm happy."

I wonder if or how these looser moments jibe with Portman's sense of control and her perception of success. "I had lucky early experiences of failure," she says. "I know I've been also very lucky to have a lot of successes that have balanced it out. But I mean, for example, my first film, *The Professional,* got horrible reviews and had no box office. And then I made *Star Wars.* I was 16, and that got murdered. It was a huge success financially, but all of it was 'They ruined the franchise. None of them can act. They all suck.'"

I offer that that kind of criticism, at least for me as a teenager (and I imagine for many others), would have been crippling. Portman found it motivating. "I think it was an amazing early lesson in how to read really bad things about yourself and then be able to be like, 'I'm going to make another one. I'm going to show them,'" she says. "I don't remember *(Continued on page 112)*



*Dress,* DIOR. *Tiffany HardWear necklaces and Bird on a Rock by Tiffany Lovebirds rings,* TIFFANY & CO.

*Dress,* SIMONE ROCHA.
*Tiffany HardWear earrings and rings,* TIFFANY & CO.

*Scarf coat and skirt,* ALAÏA.
*Tights,* FALKE.

*Dress,* LOEWE. *Bird on a Rock by Tiffany Wings earrings,* TIFFANY & CO. *Sandals,* DIOR.

*Dress and bonnet,* LOUIS VUITTON.
*Pumps,* DIOR.

HAIR: OLIVIER SCHAWALDER FOR DYSON; MAKEUP: LUCY BRIDGE; MANICURE: BEATRICE ENI FOR MANUCURIST; PRODUCTION: PRODN; SET DESIGN: HELLA KECK

# *Fine* FORM

Photographs by CHARLOTTE STOUVENOT
Styling by BERENGER PELC

*This page: Dress,* JEAN PAUL GAULTIER. *Earrings (also on opposite page), vintage. Tights,* CALZEDONIA. *Mules,* DOLCE & GABBANA. *Opposite page: Top and skirt,* DIOR. *Mules,* DOLCE & GABBANA.

SCULPTURAL *silhouettes,* CINCHED *waists, and* SHEER *lace:*
# FALL'S DRAMATIC *new take on* GLAMOUR *is equal parts* RESTRAINT *and* ROMANCE

*This page: Top, leggings, and pumps,* GUCCI. *Opposite page: Jacket,* MARC JACOBS. *Bodysuit,* FLEUR DU MAL. *Tights,* CALZEDONIA. *Mules,* DOLCE & GABBANA.

*This page: Top and pants,* MIU MIU. *Opposite page: Trench-coat dress,* BURC AKYOL.

*This page: Top,* TOTEME. *Leggings,* BALENCIAGA. *Mules,* DOLCE & GABBANA. *Opposite page: Blouse and skirt,* ROBERTO CAVALLI.

*This page: Jacket and skirt,* SCHIAPARELLI. *Mules,* DOLCE & GABBANA. *Opposite page: Top,* BURC AKYOL. *Skirt,* FENDI.

*This page: Top, culottes, socks, and mules,* DOLCE & GABBANA. *Opposite page: Jacket,* BALMAIN. *Leggings,* BALENCIAGA. *Mules,* DOLCE & GABBANA.

*This page: Sweater and pants,* MAX MARA. *Hat,* LANVIN. *Belt,* ALAÏA. *Mules,* DOLCE & GABBANA. *Opposite page: Bodysuit,* COURRÈGES.

MODEL: KAROLINA SPAKOWSKI; HAIR: AKEMI KISHIDA; MAKEUP: ANTHONY PREEL; MANICURE: BEATRICE ENI FOR MANUCURIST; CASTING: ANITA BITTON AT THE ESTABLISHMENT; PRODUCTION: WHITE DOT

# *Full* BLOOM

Photographs by PETER LANGER
Accessories Director:
MIGUEL ENAMORADO

*The season's most exquisite* HIGH-JEWELRY *pieces are glimmering* BOUQUETS *of extraordinary* CRAFTSMANSHIP *and boundless* CREATIVITY

*This page: Scarabée Divin necklace from the Fascinating Egypt collection,* VAN CLEEF & ARPELS. *Opposite page: Red Carpet Collection necklace,* CHOPARD.

*Centaure necklace,* HERMÈS.

*Princess rubellite necklace,*
POMELLATO.

*Diorissima necklace,*
DIOR HIGH JEWELRY.

*Raffia tanzanite necklace from the 2026 Blue Book collection,* TIFFANY & CO.

*Flora necklace,* GUCCI
HIGH JEWELRY.

*Fortitude necklace from the Mythica collection,* LOUIS VUITTON HIGH JEWELRY.

*Groove choker and pompon necklace from the Terres de Contrastes high-jewelry collection,* MESSIKA.

*Symbole Étoile necklace,*
CHANEL HIGH JEWELRY.

*Flower necklace from the Carte Blanche Human Being high-jewelry collection,* BOUCHERON.

*Le Chœur des Pierres high-jewelry necklace,* CARTIER.

PRODUCTION: MARIA JOHNSEN

*On Boylston: Dress,* DIOR. *Clash de Cartier earrings,* CARTIER. *Pumps,* JIMMY CHOO. *On Whiteside: Top and pants,* SAINT LAURENT BY ANTHONY VACCARELLO. *Loafers,* EMPORIO ARMANI.

# LAST *Dance*

## ISABELLA BOYLSTON *and* JAMES WHITESIDE *will go down in* HISTORY *as one of* BALLET'S *great* PARTNERSHIPS. *Ahead of Whiteside's* RETIREMENT, *and following the* BIRTH *of Boylston's first* CHILD, *the duo prepare to dance their* FINAL SEASON *together.*

Story by SARAH HOOVER
Photographs by RAHIM FORTUNE
Styling by NICHOLAS GRASA

The myth of the "artist genius"—a solitary prodigy, usually male, allowing his God-given talent to flow with little influence or intervention from outside sources—has persisted since the Renaissance. Of course, we know now that even da Vinci worked with a studio team, that Rembrandt mostly painted the faces of his figures while his assistants painted everything else and he may have used mirrors and a camera obscura to achieve a photographic level of detail. In reality, the creative act is rarely undertaken alone.

For a ballerina, perhaps the most important collaborator is not the choreographer, who dictates the steps, or the composer, who times the counts, but the dance partner who helps demonstrate to an audience the extreme possibilities of what the human body can achieve creatively. A single dancer, of course, lifts the leg, points the foot, finesses the tips of the fingers. But when dancers come together in partnership in the apex section of every classical ballet, in the pas de deux, a special kind of magic happens. When it's the right dancers in the right pas de deux, one plus one equals way more than two, especially when their partnership is based on real-life connection and friendship.

One of the great ballet partnerships of the past 20 years has been that of Isabella Boylston and James Whiteside, two stars of American Ballet Theatre who have transcended the genre to mainstream adoration. Together they have almost 1.2 million Instagram followers. Whiteside also performs in drag, makes music, and is a filmmaker, and he has choreographed projects for Taylor Swift and Mariah Carey. Boylston is a fashion muse who hosts a digital literature series (Ballerina Book Club), has danced with Carly Rae Jepsen and Laufey, and appeared as Jennifer Lawrence's dance double in *Red Sparrow*.

Next summer, Whiteside, who is 42, will retire after 15 years with ABT. Boylston, 40, who marked 20 years with the company this year, welcomed her first child in June and returned to the barre six weeks after giving birth in order to partner with Whiteside starting in December. Whiteside's final performance will be as Count Albrecht opposite Boylston in *Giselle* on June 30 at the Metropolitan Opera House.

THE PAIR FIRST danced together in 2012, on tour in Barcelona, when Boylston was meant to perform *Don Quixote* with another male partner who was unexpectedly injured. Whiteside and Boylston exploded onto the stage with a natural radiance that resonated with audiences immediately. "Our connection is so intuitive," says Boylston. "I'd say that creates the perfect environment for spontaneity onstage. If I had to go onstage with him tonight in *Swan Lake,* with zero rehearsal, I'd still feel good about it."

They each separately told me their work onstage feels "cozy," a word I love for its proximity to safety—something I've always felt when watching them. They go for it, but you know that they're going to pull it off. "We came onstage with a similar sort of American attack," explains Whiteside, "and we just understood each other right away."

Next month, at the Segerstrom Art Center in Orange County, California, the pair will perform their final *Nutcracker* together. The *Nutcracker* is the most iconic classical ballet, the one you learn as a child. It's the third gem in the trifecta of *Swan Lake* and *The Sleeping Beauty,* with the most lush of Tchaikovsky's scores. It resets the annual calendar in the short life of a ballet ➤

dancer: a mark of another year passing, another season of extreme dedication coming to a close. And it is fitting that Whiteside will finish out this winter as the Nutcracker prince, with Boylston as his princess.

"I feel like it's a slightly insane decision for me to try to come back from having a baby into something as brutally hard as the Ratmansky *Nutcracker,*" Boylston says. "I'm not putting any pressure on myself to look exactly the way I did before. I just want to be there for James and be in the moment and put on a fun show."

THROUGHOUT BALLET history, there have been legendary dance partners who have captured the public imagination. Margot Fonteyn and Rudolf Nureyev became international celebrities in the 1960s. From the moment the curtain fell on their debut performance in 1962 (when they received 23 curtain calls), they were trailed by paparazzi. "When she left the stage in her great white tutu, I would have followed her to the end of the world," Nureyev said of his ballerina. In the 1970s, Mikhail Baryshnikov and Gelsey Kirkland were megastars. He would go on to become an Academy Award–nominated actor for *The Turning Point* (which was based on the lives of ABT dancers) and play one of Carrie Bradshaw's love interests on *Sex and the City;* she would write a best-selling memoir.

Isabella Boylston and James Whiteside in *The Nutcracker*

MARTY SOHL/AMERICAN BALLET THEATRE

Whiteside and Boylston fall into this tradition of greats, but they are a partnership for the here and now. They're really talented *and* they're really funny—qualities they allow audiences both in the theater and on social media to experience in nearly equal measure.

A career at their level is dependent, first and foremost, on ability. There are, like it or not, somewhat nonnegotiable physical requirements: highly arched feet, hyperextended legs, a soft back, thigh bones that can turn 180 degrees in their sockets. You're born with them or without them. Then there's the arbitrary capacity for longevity: Plenty of dancers in peak form have succumbed to career-ending injuries in their 20s or 30s. Then there's the artistic requirement: A dancer must be a profound actor, capable of transmitting deep Shakespearean emotion without sound or strained facial expression. And then there is the mental load, which varies from run-of-the-mill performance anxiety to the ability to receive and learn from corrections given by teachers, coaches, and critics (and, these days, from strangers on the internet).

The freaky thing about Whiteside and Boylston is that they've got it all but never seem untouchable or rarefied. They call themselves the Cindies, a nickname that has morphed into alter egos they inhabit for their online dance personas. Just watch one of James's pop music videos, like "WTF," a highly choreographed fusion of vogueing and ballet (he's incredible in pointe shoes), or read Isabella's subtitles on the TikTok clip of the time she almost totally lost it at the peak moment of *Don Quixote* on the Metropolitan Opera stage. These two have broken through to vast audiences precisely because of their ability to be both untouchably talented and accessible. A modern and young audience can relate to their honesty and still appreciate their technique and stagecraft. Boylston and Whiteside have shown how the art form can be as relevant today as it was a hundred years ago, Timothée Chalamet be damned.

I came to my own love of ballet as a kid after seeing a performance of the choreographer Jerome Robbins's work *Glass Pieces,* set to the score of the minimalist composer Philip Glass. This one-act ballet evokes the busy streets of early 1980s New York City, in pointe shoes and sneakers, and it blew my mind. I did not know that ballet could look like that, and I did not understand that music could sound like that. It wasn't Beethoven, and it wasn't Britney Spears, and it had not occurred to me that there were artists out there who made music that sounded this way or dance that looked like real life, but more urgent and special. It exploded my notions of what art and life could be like. It made me want to move to wherever art like this was being made—which I figured out pretty quickly was New York City.

When my son was four, I was determined to give him the same experience. I got tickets to a weekday matinee of *Swan Lake* at the Metropolitan Opera House. I figured it was a story simple enough for a kid to follow; if not, there's both a green swamp monster and a possessed Black Swan demon in the third act. There's fog and some brief pyrotechnics. *Bluey* doesn't have any of that! I even made arrangements to sneak him backstage at intermission. As soon as the curtain closed on Act Two, the white swans having fluttered their way into the wings, we rushed backstage to see Boylston, resplendent in her tutu and tiara, her perfectly dewy skin showing through dramatic stage makeup. "You were pristine," I told her. (She's always pristine. That's part of her thing.) "Was I?" she asked, giving my little boy a hug. "Because my toe really hurts. I think I have to undo my pointe shoe and rip my big toenail off before I go back on stage for Act Three." She turned to my son: "Do you want to watch?" He broke into a big smile.

IN 2021, Whiteside ruptured a patellar tendon onstage while dancing in the *Nutcracker* at Segerstrom. (ABT has performed *Nutcracker* there since 2015.) It's a performance that he jokes "traumatized thousands of people in the audience" and, more seriously, could have been a career-ending catastrophe. Through hard work and sheer will, he was able to return a mere year later, to a reception from California's audiences that was as loud as a Beyoncé concert. And for his last *Nutcracker,* he will dance, of course, with his Cindy, who herself will be coming back from childbirth, with barely a five-month turnaround time. (This is the kind of dedication and fortitude that separates *(Continued on page 112)*

*On Boylston: Dress,* HERMÈS. *On Whiteside: Shirt,* GIORGIO ARMANI.

HAIR AND MAKEUP: MARIYA PILTYEVA.
SPECIAL THANKS TO GLOSS

## NATALIE PORTMAN

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 76

talking to anyone about it. I didn't want to show anyone that I was hurt or anything."

Portman's next feel-good project after *The Gallerist* is Lena Dunham's rom-com *Good Sex*. She plays a couples therapist who is also newly back on the dating scene, and her love interests are played by Mark Ruffalo and Tucker Pillsbury, a.k.a. Role Model, in his first movie. "I could not have asked for a better costar for my first film," Pillsbury says. "She is so patient and kind. She held my hand through the whole thing."

Portman relished diving into playing a couples therapist. "You're figuring out how a system works, not how an individual works," she says. "One thing sparks another, which sparks another, which sparks another. And it becomes this infinity loop. You're trying to identify what that loop is and then break that loop."

**IN THE GALLERY,** Portman lingered in front of a painting with words and symbols strewn across it. As we made our way out, Portman asked the gallerist about it; it seemed laden with meaning. The gallerist shrugged. It's a love letter from the artist to her grandson, he explained. He handed us each the catalogue for the exhibit, which opened with an essay by the novelist Rachel Cusk.

I made nothing of it at the time. Portman has long aligned herself with feminist artists and intellectuals; Snyder and Cusk easily fall into those categories. She is a big reader and runs a book club on Instagram. Cusk's *Parade* was Portman's June 2024 book-club pick; the caption on her Instagram announcing the selection reads, "Forever in awe of Rachel Cusk and the way she disrupts form and the conventions of storytelling."

In hindsight, it seems like foreshadowing. A few weeks after we speak, galleys of Cusk's new book, *Life of M,* start to leak. The novel is an unsparing meditation on the vacuousness of fame, and its main character, M, is a celebrity whose story mirrors Portman's. One reviewer described Cusk's M as a "big, dumb doll; pampered and pretentious; wholly incapable of love, originality, moral consideration, even real feeling." The news ricochets around the internet, sparking debates on whether the novel is a "literary assassination" or not really about Portman at all or whether Portman and her life are fair game in this way.

Cusk has refused to say if M is Portman. Portman has declined to comment on the book at all. Comments on Portman's two-year-old Instagram post announcing *Parade* as Portman's book-club selection have been limited.

One way to interpret Cusk's book is that Portman is an efficient proxy for the way we project onto a celebrity, especially if the celebrity has been a part of our lives for a long time, and especially if we feel like we know the celebrity intimately because we grew up with him or her. The current culture demands vulnerability and accessibility from its stars—confessions and goofy TikTok dances and mea culpas on social media. Portman has done such a good job disappearing into her characters, and safeguarding her personal life, that there is still a sense of unknowability about her.

As our interview draws to close, I gently press Portman about her new relationship—whether it feels different, and good, to be in one as a fully formed adult. "Yeah," she says. "Actually, in the exhibit, I was thinking about how nice it is to see an artist in her 80s just be like, 'I'm going to make this about the love of my grandkid.' When we were like, 'What does this mean?' And it's just for her grandkid because she loves him. I was thinking, 'That's what a badass woman who's been around is like: Guess what? The most important thing is love. And I'm not embarrassed to say it.' I do feel like it's so simple, just being kind and loving and being able to laugh. That's all that matters. That's the joy of being this age. If it's not that, I'm not spending my time there." **HB**

## LAST DANCE

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the pros from the greats.) "It will be extra special," Boylston says, "because *Nutcracker* was the last thing I performed when I was already three months pregnant. So in a way, James and Magnus [her baby] have already performed together."

Their partnership will also be on view next June at Whiteside's final show, *Giselle*, back home at New York's Met Opera. *Giselle* is the story of a young peasant girl who is seduced by Count Albrecht, only to find out that he is not only secretly an aristocrat but also betrothed to another. She dies of a broken heart in front of her mother, then drags Albrecht into the Land of the Willis, inhabited by women who have died lovesick and torture their fuckboys by making them dance to death. As a protofeminist masterpiece, it's one of my favorites, though in the end Giselle lets Albrecht return safely to the land of the living, loyal to him into eternity. It is also one of the most difficult ballets in the classical canon, a challenge for the most accomplished dancer. "James is really good at reading me and anticipating my needs, and thank God, because sometimes I do some weird shit onstage," jokes Boylston. "He also has that old-school thing of taking immense pride in his partnering and putting his partner first." It is this sort of chivalrous lack of hubris, countered by virtuoso ability, that defines Whiteside's career.

The way you do something is the way you do everything, of course, and it's no fluke that these two have forged such a generational partnership and no surprise that Whiteside has a precise vision for what is to come. "I feel really good about my 25-year career as a performing artist," he says. "I'm grateful, of course, for all of it. I really look forward to new opportunities in choreography. I also want to publish another book and a photo book." Boylston will partner with someone new, but Whiteside will always be her Cindy. **HB**

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# ARCHIVE

## MADONNA, JUNE 1990

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LONG BEFORE reinvention became a signature swerve for pop stars, actors, and other erstwhile masters of the monoculture, Madonna made it her artistic medium. She didn't simply unveil a new look with every album cycle; she treated performance itself as her creative engine. Music, fashion, film, choreography, photography, celebrity—they all belonged to the same evolving work, with each appearance another opportunity to reshape the mythology she was constructing around herself. Madonna's June 1990 *Harper's Bazaar* cover story arrived at a pivotal moment in the evolution of that project. She had just launched the groundbreaking Blond Ambition tour, transforming the pop concert into avant-garde theater, and was in the process of making *Truth or Dare,* Alek Keshishian's notorious (and prescient) behind-the-scenes documentary, which blurred the line between backstage and onstage. That summer, she starred in *Dick Tracy,* a live-action riff on the 1930s detective comic noir directed by Warren Beatty, with whom she was romantically involved in real life; she also released an entire album, *I'm Breathless,* inspired by her character, Breathless Mahoney. Jean-Baptiste Mondino, who photographed Madonna for *Bazaar,* was a key creative partner for her at the time—as was Jean Paul Gaultier, who designed the gold bodysuit with quilted cone-shaped cups in the image here that she wore for her tour. In all of it, there was an element of experimentation but also an appetite for risk that today, in the age of brand strategists and engagement metrics, seems almost freewheeling. The accompanying profile by Margy Rochlin captured her creative restlessness in real time. "I'm impulsive and I don't mull things over," Madonna said. "And when I make big mistakes, they're glaring." But her self-assurance was the kind that only comes from knowing who you are. Rochlin later described Madonna arriving at her own party, only to be stopped by an unwitting doorperson who asked her for her name to see if she was on the guest list. "Donna," she replied. "Ma." **HB**

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